

The Port Rats

a novel of the Lowers



Patrick

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All characters depicted are adults.

For mature readers. Contains explicit sexual content, violence, and strong language.

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Chapter One

Landfall



The *Harren's Wake* groaned against the moorings like a drunk leaning on a stranger. Three months of open sea had turned the timber black with salt crust, and the rigging hung limp and frayed, barely worth the rope it was knotted from. Jonah Wren stood at the port rail with everything he owned in a canvas bag slung across one shoulder: two shirts, a razor, a tintype of a woman he no longer loved, and eleven copper marks that wouldn't buy him a week in whatever shithole waited past the gangplank.

He was twenty-six. Looked thirty. Six-one with the kind of build that came from labor, not vanity—wide across the shoulders, thick through the forearms, hands scarred white at the knuckles from a decade of ironwork. His jaw was sharp under three weeks of stubble, dark hair cropped short and uneven where he'd done it himself with the razor sometime mid-crossing. His eyes were the pale grey of river stones, set deep beneath a heavy brow that made him look like he was perpetually deciding whether to hit something. He wasn't. Most of the time.

The coat he wore had been decent once. Dark wool, double-breasted, brass buttons stamped with the crest of the Aldworth Foundry. That crest meant nothing here. The Aldworth had burned six months ago, torched by Leveller militias during the Second Reclamation, and whatever life Jonah had built around its furnaces had gone up with it. Smoke and memory.

He spat over the rail into water the color of piss.

The port city of Veranesse spread before him like a wound trying to heal. It climbed the hillside in uneven tiers: dockside was all timber warehouses and tarred planking, fish-stink and coal smoke rolling off the water in a yellow haze. Above that, the merchant quarter, redbrick and iron-framed, with rail lines cutting through on elevated trestles that hissed and clanked as steam-coaches rattled past trailing plumes of white vapor. Higher still, visible only as a smear of pale stone and copper roofing, the Crescent—where the old families lived. Where money lived. Where people like Jonah Wren did not go unless they were carrying something heavy for someone else.

Clank-clank-clank-clank.

The gangplank dropped. Bodies surged.

Jonah let them go first. Immigrants, most of them: Brevish, Calleni, a handful of Rekkers from the eastern provinces with their wool caps and suspicious eyes. They shuffled down the plank with the hollow enthusiasm of people who'd been promised something they didn't quite believe in yet. The New Communion. The great experiment. Sovereignty for all, allegedly. Parliament without kings.

Jonah believed in sovereignty the way he believed in weather—it existed, it happened to you, and you couldn't do a goddamn thing about who was standing in the rain.

He walked down the gangplank with his bag over his shoulder and his jaw set.

The docks hit him like a wall. Noise—*thwack-thwack-thwack* of fish being gutted on stone slabs, the screech of rail brakes somewhere above, a steamhorn bellowing from a barge in the inner harbor. The smell was worse: brine, offal, coal, and underneath all of it, the sweet-rot tang of fruit going bad in the heat. Veranesse in summer. Wonderful.

He made it fourteen steps onto solid ground before someone robbed him.

He felt it—a whisper of pressure against his left hip, fingers quick and practiced sliding under the flap of his coat toward the inner pocket where the eleven coppers sat in a leather fold. Fast. Professional. The kind of touch that came from years of practice on men who weren't paying attention.

Jonah was paying attention.

His hand closed around a wrist, thin, warm, surprisingly strong, and he pivoted hard, dragging the thief around in front of him.

"The fuck do you think—"

He stopped.

She was small. Five-three, maybe five-four in the heeled boots she wore, and built like a whip: lean, narrow-waisted, with the kind of tight, compact frame that came from running more than eating. Her face was angular, sharp-featured, a pointed chin beneath a wide mouth that was currently twisted in a snarl. Her skin was tanned deep brown by sun and dockside living, and her hair, dark auburn, almost black in the shadow, was pulled back in a messy knot held together by what looked like a bent nail. She wore a man's linen shirt three sizes too big, sleeves rolled to the elbows, tucked into a leather corset that had been repaired so many times it looked like a patchwork map. Trousers—actual trousers, not skirts—cut off below the knee, and those heeled boots, scuffed down to bare leather at the toes.

Her eyes were green. Not poetic green, not emerald or jade or any of that horseshit—green like glass bottles, like harbor water where the light caught it. And they were furious.

"Let go of me," she said. Low voice. Dockside accent, vowels flattened and hard.

"You had your hand in my coat."

"I was steadying myself. The plank's wet."

"You were four meters from the plank."

She tried to twist free. He held. She was strong for her size but he had sixty pounds on her and the leverage of a man who'd spent his twenties pulling molten iron.

"I've got eleven coppers," he said. "Total. That's everything I own that isn't cloth or steel. You really want to be the person who takes that from a man on his first day?"

Something shifted in her face. Not guilt. She didn't have the machinery for guilt, he could tell. But calculation. Reassessment. She stopped pulling.

"Eleven coppers won't last you three days here," she said.

"Then they're not worth stealing."

"Everything's worth stealing. Some things just aren't worth getting caught for."

He let go of her wrist. She stepped back, rubbing the spot where his grip had been, those green eyes taking his measure the way a merchant weighs coin, quick, practiced, and utterly without sentiment.

"Mary," she said. Not an introduction. A concession.

"Jonah."

"Jonah." She said it like she was tasting it. Deciding if it was worth remembering. "You just off the *Wake*?"

"No, I swam."

The corner of her mouth twitched. Not a smile. The ghost of one. The possibility that a smile might, under different circumstances, consider visiting.

"You need work," she said. It wasn't a question.

"I need a lot of things."

"Work first. Everything else follows. I know people."

"Thieves."

"People who *know* things. There's a difference." She tilted her head, that sharp chin angling upward. "Eleven coppers. Three days. After that, you're sleeping on the quay and eating fish guts. Or you walk with me and have a roof by sundown."

The steamhorn blared again from the harbor. Gulls screamed. Somewhere up the hill, a rail-coach clattered past on its iron trestle, trailing white smoke into the yellowing sky.

Jonah picked up his bag.

Mary turned and walked into Veranesse without looking back, her heeled boots clicking a quick *tak-tak-tak* against the wet stone, and he followed her into the noise and the heat and the stink of the city that was supposed to be his second chance.

Chapter Two

The Red Lamp



Mary set him up in a room above a chandler's shop on Bent Street. Four walls, a straw mattress that smelled like someone had died on it—possibly twice—and a window that looked onto the back of a slaughterhouse. The chandler was a fat Calleni named Rosso who owed Mary something she didn't explain. Two coppers a week. Nine left.

Jonah sat on the mattress and stared at the ceiling and tried to remember the last time he'd had a woman.

Couldn't. Somewhere before the Reclamation. Before the foundry burned. Some barmaid in Harwick whose name he'd forgotten before his trousers were back on. That was—what—four months ago? Five? Then the chaos, then the running, then ninety-two days in the belly of the *Wake* with two hundred unwashed bodies, a shared piss bucket, and not enough privacy to even get a proper pull off without some Rekker snoring three feet from his head.

His cock had been half-hard since he stepped off the gangplank. The sea air, solid ground under his feet, women walking past who weren't malnourished refugees—his body was done waiting. He could feel it in his balls, that heavy ache that sat low and constant like a second heartbeat. Three months of nothing. His dick was practically filing a grievance.

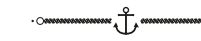
"Where's the nearest whorehouse?" he'd asked Mary before she left.

She hadn't flinched. "The Burnt Rose. Two streets east, red lamp. Ask for Della, tell her I sent you. Two coppers for the hour."

"How's the talent?"

"Better than your hand."

Fair enough.



He found a pump in the yard and stripped down. Dumped cold water over himself until the runoff stopped looking like sewage. Scraped the razor over his jaw. Sniffed his own armpit—passable. Put on the shirt without the hole and walked east with his cock already stiffening against his thigh like it knew where they were headed.

The Burnt Rose was a crooked three-story shitbox leaning sideways like a drunk at last call, with a red glass lantern above the door and the sound of a squeeze-box being murdered inside. He pushed through the door into a fog of tobacco smoke, cheap perfume, and the unmistakable musk of a place where people fucked for money.

Thump-thump-thump went the squeeze-box. Somewhere upstairs, a headboard was knocking against a wall in a rhythm that wasn't subtle.

The parlor was what you'd expect: furniture that had been sat on, spilled on, and screwed on in roughly equal measure. Half a dozen men in various states of drunk, and women draped over them like cats on warm furniture. A redhead in the corner had her tits mostly out of her corset and was laughing at something a sailor was saying. She wasn't laughing because it was funny.

Della ran the bar. Mid-fifties, built like a brick shithouse, grey hair pinned up tight, with a face that said she'd seen every desperate hard-on walk through that door and didn't find a single one of them interesting. She poured gin into glasses that had never met soap.

"Mary Grieve sent me," Jonah said.

Della looked him over like livestock at auction. Four seconds flat.

"Just off the boat?"

"That obvious?"

"Sweetheart, you're looking at my bar taps like you want to fuck them." She slid a gin across. "Two coppers. One hour. Don't hit, don't bite unless she says so, and if she tells you to stop, you stop or Bruno breaks something you'll miss." She jerked her chin toward the bald mountain of a man at the end of the bar. Bruno cracked his knuckles. *Pop-pop-pop.*

Jonah put the coppers down. Seven left. Worth it. Absolutely fucking worth it.

Della whistled, sharp, two-fingered, loud as a rail brake, and a woman came down the stairs.

Jonah's brain went blank.

She was tall. Five-nine, easy. Dark-skinned, deep brown with copper undertones that caught the lamplight like she was generating her own heat. Black hair, loose, heavy, falling past her shoulders in waves that moved when she breathed. She wore a silk robe, pale blue, thin as tissue, tied loosely at the waist, and underneath it—nothing. Not a goddamn thing. He could see everything through the fabric. The full, heavy curve of her tits, nipples pressing dark against the silk. The dip of her waist. The swell of her hips. The shadow between her thighs. She walked down those stairs like she had all night and knew exactly what every man in the room was thinking, and she was right, because every man in the room was thinking the same thing.

"Lina," Della said. "Mary's boy. Fresh off the boat, three months dry. Don't kill him."

Lina stopped on the second step and looked down at Jonah with heavy-lidded brown eyes that had *fuck me* and *pay me* in perfect equilibrium.

"You look hungry," she said. Brevish accent. Soft consonants. Voice like warm honey poured over gravel.

"Starving," he said, and meant it in every way a man could mean it.

"Then come eat."

She turned and went back up. The robe clung to her ass with every step—round, firm, shifting left-right-left—and Jonah downed the gin like it was water and followed her up those stairs two at a time.

The room was small. Bed, iron frame, clean sheets. Candle. Shuttered window. She closed the door and the latch clicked and the noise from downstairs dropped away and it was just the two of them and the candlelight and his heartbeat pounding in his ears like a war drum.

Lina turned around and untied the sash. The robe fell open. She let it hang there for a second—letting him look, because looking was part of it, and she was worth looking at. Full tits, heavy enough to sway when she moved, dark nipples already stiff in the cool air. A stomach that was soft without being flat, the kind of body that was built for grabbing, for pulling close, for sinking

into. Wide hips. A neat strip of dark hair between her thighs. Legs that went on forever.

Jonah's cock was so hard it hurt.

"Sit," she said.

He sat on the edge of the bed. She shrugged the robe off completely—it hit the floor with a whisper—and walked over to him naked as the day, stepping between his knees. She took his jaw in both hands and tilted his face up. Her tits were right there, inches from his mouth, and it took every ounce of discipline he had not to just bury his face in them.

"When's the last time?" she asked.

"Too fucking long."

"Mmh." She smiled. A real one. The kind a woman gives when she knows she's about to wreck you and is looking forward to it. "We'll fix that."

She kissed him. Not tender—firm, open-mouthed, her tongue sliding against his, tasting like clove and gin. His hands went straight to her ass, both palms full, squeezing, pulling her forward onto his lap. She came willingly, her thighs spreading over his, settling her weight right on his cock through his trousers, and the pressure and the heat of her made him groan into her mouth —a low, guttural sound he hadn't made in months.

"*Nngh*—fuck," he breathed.

"Shirt off," she said against his lips.

He yanked it over his head. She ran her hands down his chest, fingernails dragging light over his stomach, tracing the burn scars on his ribs.

"You're built like a draft horse," she said.

"Thanks."

"Wasn't a compliment. Means you can take what I give you."

Her hand dropped between them. She palmed his cock through the trousers—wrapped her fingers around the shape of it and squeezed, slow, deliberate, and his hips bucked up involuntarily.

"*Jesus*—"

"Mmhm. Big boy came hungry." She was already working his belt, fingers quick and practiced, popping the buckle, tugging the leather free. She undid the buttons and reached inside, and her hand closed around him skin to skin —warm, firm, knowing—and Jonah's head dropped back and he stared at the ceiling and his vision went white at the edges.

Three months. Three months of salt water and stale air and nothing but his own fist, and now this woman's hand on his cock, stroking slow, thumb circling the tip where he was already leaking, and it was almost too much. Almost. The kind of almost that makes you clench your jaw and think about dead fish and ice water because if you don't, it's over in thirty seconds and you've wasted a copper per minute.

"Don't you dare," she said, reading him. "Not yet."

She pushed him flat on his back. The iron frame screamed—*CRREEAAAK*—loud enough that someone downstairs whooped. She climbed on top of him, straddling his hips, and reached down between her own thighs, touching herself first—two fingers sliding through slick heat—then guided him in.

He grabbed her hips hard enough to leave marks and pulled her down and she took all of him in one slow, deliberate drop, and the sound she made—*"Ahhh"*—was half performance, half genuine, and he didn't give a shit about the ratio because the feeling of her—hot, tight, wet, *alive*—was so good it was nearly religious.

She started moving. Slow at first. Rolling her hips in long, grinding circles, her hands flat on his chest, her tits swaying with the motion. Then faster. The bed frame protested with every thrust—*creak-creak-creak-creak*—a metronome of rusted iron keeping time while she rode him like she was trying to break something.

Jonah held on. Hands on her hips, her waist, her ass. Watching her work. The candlelight threw her shadow huge against the wall—this moving, undulating shape that looked like something from a fever dream. Sweat sheened on her skin. Her breath came in short, sharp gasps—*"Hh—hh—hh—"*—and her eyes were half-closed and her mouth was open and she was beautiful and filthy and exactly what he needed.

He lasted longer than he had any right to.

When it hit—and it hit like a freight train, like every denied, delayed, deferred need of the last three months detonating at once—he grabbed her hips and slammed her down and held her there and came so hard his vision whited out and his back arched off the mattress and he made a sound that was somewhere between a groan and a roar and probably woke up half the building.

"FUCK—"

Lina rode it out. Ground against him through every pulse, milking it, her own breath ragged, nails digging crescents into his chest.

Then stillness. The squeeze-box downstairs. His own breathing, heavy and raw. The candle guttering. Her weight on his hips, warm and real and solid.

She leaned down, her hair falling around his face like a curtain, and kissed his jaw.

"Better?" she whispered.

"Mhm."

"Good." She climbed off, casual as stepping out of a bath, and reached for the washbasin. "You've got forty minutes left. Catch your breath. We're going again."

Jonah stared at the ceiling and let the blood return to his brain one reluctant drop at a time. Outside, the red lamp burned. Below, the squeeze-box wheezed. And somewhere in the back of his mind, past the post-orgasm haze, a thought formed—small, stubborn, already rooting itself into place like a weed through cobblestone:

He was going to need to make more money.



He didn't need the full forty minutes. Fifteen and a wash from the basin and he was good. Twenty-six, three months of backlog, and a woman who looked like Lina—the math worked in his favor.

She was sitting on the edge of the bed, legs crossed, completely unbothered by her own nakedness, sipping water from a clay cup like she was at a café. Watching him the way you'd watch weather rolling in—interested but not worried.

"Again?" she asked, one eyebrow up.

"Again. But different."

"Different how?"

Jonah leaned against the windowsill and crossed his arms. The shutter was still closed but he could hear the alley below—a cat hissing at something, a drunk singing badly in Calleni, the distant *chuff-chuff-chuff* of a steam engine somewhere on the upper trestles.

"On the *Wake*, there was a Sereshi trader. Old man, been everywhere—the Jade Provinces, the Burnt Coast, all the way east past the Calleni Straits. Used to talk at night when nobody could sleep. Most of it was bullshit. Trade

routes, sea monsters, the usual. But one night he got into the topic of—" Jonah paused, searching for the right framing. "Eastern customs. Pleasure houses in the Jade Provinces. He said there was a practice the courtesans specialized in. Called it *irrumatio*."

Lina set the cup down. Her expression shifted—not shock, not offense. Professional interest. The same look a carpenter gets when someone describes an unusual joint.

"I know what that is," she said.

"Yeah?"

"Mmhm. The mouth stays still. The man does the work." She uncrossed her legs and leaned back on her palms, studying him with those heavy-lidded eyes. "Most men who ask for that don't know what they're asking for. They think it's just a rough suck. It's not. It's control. You set the pace, the depth, all of it. She takes it."

"Is that a problem?"

Lina smiled. Not the performance smile. Something sharper. Genuine. A craftswoman being asked to demonstrate a skill she was proud of.

"Sweetheart, I've been doing this since I was old enough to charge for it. Nothing you want is a problem. It's a question of whether you can handle what you're asking for." She slid off the bed and stood in front of him, that tall frame backlit by candlelight, shadows pooling in every curve. "Most men who want to control a woman's mouth last about thirty seconds once they're actually doing it. The sensation's different. More intense. You feel *everything* —the heat, the pressure, the way her throat works when she—" She made a small swallowing motion, deliberate, and his cock twitched like it had been poked with a stick. "—adjusts. It's overwhelming. You sure you want that after three months of nothing? You'll blow in a minute."

"I'll take my chances."

"Your coppers." She dropped to her knees on the bare floorboards—*thunk* —casual, practiced, like she was kneeling to tie a boot. She looked up at him from the floor and the angle did something to his brain—that face, those eyes, looking up with her lips slightly parted and her hands resting on her thighs. "Come here then."

He stepped forward. She reached up, hooked her fingers into the waist of his trousers—he'd only pulled them half up after round one—and tugged them down to his thighs. His cock was already hard again, thick and flushed

dark, standing straight out at her eye level. She looked at it the way a woman looks at a meal she's been thinking about.

"Hands in my hair," she said. "Both of them. You control everything—pace, depth, how long you stay in. I tap your thigh twice if I need air. That's the only rule."

He slid both hands into that heavy black hair. It was thick, warm, slightly damp at the temples from the earlier exertion. He gathered it at the back of her head, wrapped it around his fist once—not yanking, just holding—and she tilted her face up, opened her mouth, and looked at him with an expression that said *go ahead, use me, that's what you're paying for.*

"Fuck," he muttered. Not an exclamation. A prayer.

He guided himself in. Slow. The head of his cock slid past her lips, over her tongue—hot, wet, impossibly soft—and she held still. Completely still. Mouth open, jaw relaxed, tongue flat, eyes up. Waiting. This was the difference. A regular fuck with the mouth, she'd be moving, bobbing, working him with lips and tongue. This was the opposite. She was terrain. He was the one moving through it.

He pushed deeper. Felt the back of her mouth. Her throat tightened for a second—a reflexive clench—then relaxed, deliberately, muscles letting go one by one like she was unlocking a series of doors. The old Sereshi trader hadn't lied. The sensation was different. Tighter. Hotter. Every ridge and texture of her mouth amplified because *he* was the one controlling the motion, and his brain was registering every millimeter of movement as deliberate, chosen, his.

He pulled back. Pushed in again. Slow, finding the rhythm. Her hands stayed on her thighs. Her eyes stayed up, locked on his face, and there was something in those eyes—not submission, nothing that passive—more like *partnership*. A woman who was very good at being still in a way that required more skill than movement ever could.

"*Nngh*—" He tightened his grip in her hair. Set a pace. Steady. Not brutal—he wasn't trying to hurt her—but firm, deliberate, each stroke pushing a little deeper, holding a little longer. The sound of it filled the small room—wet, rhythmic, obscene—*glk... glk... glk...*—punctuated by his breathing, which was already ragged.

She was right. It was overwhelming. Every sensation magnified by the fact that he was choosing it—the speed, the depth, the angle. Her mouth was a furnace. Her throat worked around him each time he pushed deep—a

swallowing, rippling pressure that made his toes curl against the floorboards and his thighs tremble like he'd been running.

Creak went the floor under his shifting weight. The candle flickered. Downstairs, the squeeze-box had stopped. Someone was laughing. None of it mattered.

He sped up. Couldn't help it. His hips found a faster rhythm, pulling her head forward to meet each thrust, and she took it—eyes watering now, spit running down her chin, breath coming in quick snorts through her nose—*hhh, hhh, hhh*—but her hands never left her thighs and she never tapped out. She just *held*, rooted there on her knees like an anchor, letting him use her mouth the way a storm uses a coastline.

The old Sereshi had said the courtesans in the Jade Provinces trained for years to master this. Breath control, throat relaxation, the ability to suppress every natural reflex. Lina might not have trained in the Jade Provinces, but she'd trained somewhere, because she was taking everything he gave her without flinching, and the sounds she was making—low, guttural, vibrating around him—*mmh, mmh, mmh*—were either the best performance in Veranesse or genuine enjoyment, and again, he didn't care about the ratio.

It hit him faster than he expected. She'd warned him. Thirty seconds, she'd said, and he'd lasted longer than that—five minutes, maybe, or ten, time had stopped meaning anything—but when it came, it came all at once, a clenching wave that started in his balls and rolled up through his spine like a detonation.

"*Fuck—I'm—*"

She grabbed his hips. Not tapping out. Pulling him *in*. Deeper. Holding him there. Her throat worked—*glk, glk, glk*—swallowing around him as he came, and the sensation of that—the tight, rhythmic pressure of her throat milking him while his cock pulsed—was so intense that his knees buckled and he had to brace one hand against the wall to keep from going down.

"*Ahhhh—Christ—*"

His vision went grey. His ears rang. He was pretty sure he said something else but couldn't remember what because his brain had temporarily vacated the premises.

When it was over—when the last tremor rolled through him and his legs stopped shaking—Lina pulled back, slow, careful, and sat back on her heels. She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. Looked up at him with those heavy-lidded eyes, tears streaking her cheeks from the reflex, spit glistening on

her chin. She didn't look damaged. She looked *satisfied*. The way an athlete looks after a hard set.

"The old man on your boat," she said, her voice slightly hoarse. "He wasn't lying."

Jonah slid down the wall until he was sitting on the floor across from her, trousers around his thighs, chest heaving, every muscle in his body turned to warm liquid.

"No," he managed. "He was not."

Lina stood, walked to the basin, rinsed her mouth, splashed water on her face. Casual. Professional. A woman clocking out of a shift she was very good at.

"You've got twenty minutes," she said, toweling off. "Want water? Gin? There's bread downstairs if you're hungry."

"Water. And—Lina?"

She looked over her shoulder.

"I'm going to need to make more money."

She laughed—a real one, low and warm, the first fully unguarded sound she'd made all night—and tossed him the towel.

"Every man says that after the first time. Most of them mean it." She tilted her head, studying him. "You actually might."

He caught the towel. Wiped his face. She sat back down on the edge of the bed and poured herself water, and her eyes went to his ribs—to the burn scars she'd traced earlier, a ladder of shiny pink welts climbing his left side.

"Those aren't dock scars."

"Foundry."

"Which one?"

"Aldworth."

"Aldworth." She turned the word over. "The one the Levellers burned."

"That's the one."

"Mm." She sipped. Casual. A woman making conversation with a client while he caught his breath. "And Mary's got you where—Rosso's? Above the chandler's?"

"Bent Street."

"Bent Street," she repeated, softly, the way you'd repeat a number you wanted to remember. Then she smiled—the professional one again, the warm

one, the door sliding gently shut—and nodded at his trousers. “Get dressed, dock boy. Della charges for loitering.”

He’d learn later that nothing said in Lina’s room stayed in Lina’s room. It just waited there, folded neatly in a drawer, until someone came along with the right price.

Outside, the red lamp burned on, throwing its bloody light into the alley where the cat had stopped hissing and the drunk had stopped singing and the city of Veranesse hummed its low, endless, indifferent hum—a city that didn’t care whether Jonah Wren made more money or not, but was perfectly willing to take whatever he had.

Chapter Three

The Underbelly



Three days in Veranesse and Jonah had already learned the city's essential geometry: everything decent happened above the rail line, and everything real happened below it.

Mary found him work on the second morning, hauling crates at the Fenwick & Sallow warehouse on the inner docks, twelve hours a day, four coppers per shift. Backbreaking, mind-numbing, honest labor. The kind of work that turned your hands into leather and your thoughts into white noise. He'd done worse. The foreman was a one-eyed Rekker named Goss who didn't give a shit where you came from as long as you could lift eighty pounds without complaining. Jonah could lift eighty pounds in his sleep.

By the end of day three, he had his nine coppers back plus change. Rent paid. Food—if you could call dockside stew food—in his gut. A routine forming. Wake, work, eat, sleep. The bones of a life.

But Veranesse had other bones. Older ones. Darker.

Mary told him about the Underbelly on the third night, sitting on the steps of the chandler's shop, sharing a bottle of something that was technically gin but tasted like turpentine filtered through a sock.

"Below the Lowers," she said, picking at a scab on her knuckle. "Used to be the old sewer network before they rerouted the waterworks for the rail system. Now it's—well. It's where the things go that the Communion pretends don't exist."

"Such as?"

"Weapons. Drugs. People." She took a swig and passed the bottle. "The Communion abolished slavery three years ago. Officially. On paper. Very progressive, very noble, the Parliament congratulated itself for a week. Didn't change a fucking thing below ground. The Khett traders still run flesh markets down there. Humans, sometimes, but mostly the half-breeds."

"Half-breeds."

"Felinara. Lupara. The beast-kin." She said it the way you'd say *cockroaches*, not with hatred, but with the resigned familiarity of someone who'd grown up in a world where the distinction between person and property was drawn along species lines. "Cat-bloods, dog-bloods. The old continent used them as labor stock for centuries. Field work, mining, dock hauling. Bred them for it. Big ones for heavy lifting, small ones for tight spaces. The Communion says they're free now." She laughed, short and bitter. "Free to do what? No one hires them. Can't own property. Can't enter the Crescent. So they end up back in the markets, sold under the table to anyone with coin and a use for something that doesn't complain."

Jonah stared at the bottle in his hand. The gin tasted worse with context.

"Where's the entrance?"

Mary looked at him sideways. Those green glass-bottle eyes, calculating.

"Why?"

"Curious."

"Bullshit. You've got that look."

"What look?"

"The one that means you're about to do something stupid and expensive." She sighed and took the bottle back. "Storm drain behind the old tannery on Corvis Street. Iron grate, usually unlocked after dark. Follow the left channel until you hit the lanterns. Don't touch anything, don't stare at anyone, and for fuck's sake, don't start a fight. The Khett don't play by Communion rules down there."

He went the next night.

The storm drain was right where she said, a rusted iron grate set into the base of the old tannery wall, three feet wide, hinged on one side and hanging open like a broken jaw. The smell hit him before the dark did. Mildew,

standing water, old stone, and underneath it something animal: musk and fur and the copper tang of blood, faint but unmistakable.

He ducked inside. The tunnel was brick, low-ceilinged, dripping. His boots splashed through an inch of stagnant water that reflected nothing. Twenty yards in, the tunnel branched. Left channel. Lanterns appeared: oil lamps hooked into iron brackets on the walls, spaced just far enough apart to make the shadows between them feel deliberate. Like the dark was part of the merchandise.

Drip. Drip. Drip.

The tunnel opened into a vaulted chamber. An old cistern, maybe, circular, thirty feet across, with a domed ceiling lost in shadow above. Market stalls lined the perimeter, if you could call them stalls. Wooden tables. Canvas tarps. Crates repurposed as display counters. The vendors were mostly Khett—tall, angular men with the sun-darkened skin and ritual scarring of the eastern trade clans, dressed in layered linens and leather, curved knives worn openly on their belts. They sold what Mary had described: weapons laid out on oiled cloth, glass vials of things Jonah didn't want to identify, bundles of dried herbs that smelled sweet and wrong.

And at the far end of the cistern, past the weapons and the drugs and the contraband, behind a rope barrier guarded by two Khett with arms like bridge cables—the pens.

Iron cages. Twelve of them, arranged in two rows of six, each about four feet by six feet. Big enough to sit in. Not big enough to stand.

Jonah's jaw tightened so hard his molars creaked.

Most of the cages were empty. Three held occupants. In the first, a Lupara male, big, grey-furred, muzzled, sitting with his knees drawn up and his yellow eyes tracking movement with the flat resignation of something that had stopped hoping. In the second, another Lupara, smaller, curled up and sleeping—or pretending to. In the third—

Jonah stopped walking.

She was sitting with her back against the bars, knees pulled to her chest, arms wrapped around her shins. Small. Five-two, maybe five-three. Slight build, narrow shoulders, the kind of frame that looked like it had been designed for speed rather than strength. Her skin was pale, not white, but a warm ivory, like cream left in sunlight. And where her hair should have been, there was a short, thick mane of copper-auburn that fell to her jaw in choppy,

uneven layers, like someone had hacked it short with a blade. Two ears sat atop her head—*cat* ears, triangular, furred the same copper-auburn, twitching faintly in the lamplight with a motion that was involuntary, reflexive, the way a cat's ears rotate toward sound. A thin tail, furred and dark-tipped, curled around her ankles.

Her face was—*human*. That was the thing that hit him. Mostly human. Heart-shaped, fine-boned, with a small nose and a mouth that might have been pretty if it wasn't pressed into a hard, flat line. Her eyes were large, slightly too large for her face, and the irises were amber, not brown, not gold, but actual amber, the color of old resin, with vertical slit pupils that caught the lamplight and threw it back in bright flashes. She had a scattering of freckle-like markings across her cheekbones and the bridge of her nose, darker than her skin, almost like the ghost of a tabby pattern.

She wore a rough-spun shift that hung to mid-thigh, shapeless, colorless, the kind of garment you'd put on livestock to keep the flies off. No shoes. Her feet were bare and dirty, and her toes were—not quite right. Slightly longer than human, with nails that curved faintly downward. Not claws. Almost claws.

She was looking at him.

Not with fear. Not with hope. With a kind of ferocious, unblinking assessment that reminded him, absurdly, immediately, of Mary. The same calculating stare. *What are you? What do you want? What can I get from you before you take what you came for?*

Her ears flattened against her skull. A warning.

"You want, you buy. No touching through bars." The voice came from behind the rope barrier: one of the Khett guards, a tall bastard with ritual scars running from his temples to his jaw in parallel lines that made his face look like sheet music. "Looking is free. Everything else costs."

"How much for her?" Jonah asked.

The words were out before he'd decided to say them. His mouth had made a decision his brain hadn't authorized, which was becoming a pattern in this city.

The Khett guard looked at him. Looked at the cage. Looked back.

"The Felinara?" A shrug. "Runt stock. Low labor value. Caught her topside three weeks ago, living in a drain pipe, stealing fish from the market. No training, no breeding papers, no compliance conditioning. She bites."

He held up his left hand. A fresh scar ran across the meat of his palm. "Fifteen silvers."

Jonah had no silvers. He had coppers. Fifteen silvers was—he did the math—a hundred and fifty coppers. Nearly ten weeks of dock wages, assuming he didn't eat or pay rent.

"Ten," Jonah said.

"Fifteen. She's young. Good teeth. Another buyer wants her for a private household, but he hasn't come back with the coin yet. Left his mark, though." The Khett tapped his collar. Pinned to the layered linen was a small silver brooch: a single leaf, finely worked, the veins etched so delicately they caught the lamplight like frost. Not Khett work. Not Lowers work. Not anything that had any business being in a sewer. "Ash leaf. Rich-house token. Means he's good for it. You bring fifteen silvers by end of week, she's yours. You don't, she goes to him."

"What does he want her for?"

The Khett's expression said *what do you think, idiot* without moving a muscle.

The girl in the cage hadn't moved. Those amber eyes were still fixed on Jonah's face, pupils contracted to thin black slits in the lamplight. Her ears were still flat. Her tail had tightened around her ankles. She looked like a coiled spring in a sack.

"I'll get the money," Jonah said.

"End of week. After that—" The Khett drew a finger across his throat. Not a threat to the girl. A gesture of finality. Transaction closed, merchandise moved, nothing personal.

Jonah looked at the cage one more time. The girl looked back. Something passed between them—not understanding, not connection, nothing that clean. Something more like mutual recognition. Two creatures in a place neither of them belonged, both calculating odds.

Her ears lifted a fraction of an inch. Not relaxed. *Listening.*

He turned and walked back through the cistern, past the weapons stalls and the drug vendors and the oil lamps throwing shadows on sweating brick, back up the left channel through the dripping dark, out through the rusted grate into the alley behind the tannery where the night air hit him like a slap and the stars hung cold and indifferent above the rooftops of the Lowers.

A hundred and fifty coppers. Ten weeks of wages. Or—

He thought of Mary. Mary who knew people. Mary who knew *things*. Mary who could turn eleven coppers into a roof and a job in an afternoon.

He started walking toward Bent Street, boots splashing through puddles that reflected the gaslight in broken orange streaks, and his mind was already running the numbers, not the math of labor and honest wages, but the other math, the faster math, the kind that happened below the rail line where the Communion's laws were just words on paper and money moved the way water moved: downhill, fast, and into whatever cracks were open.

He was going to need more than dock work for this.

Chapter Four

The Wolf in Wool



Mary called him insane. Then she called him an idiot. Then she poured two drinks, sat down, and started planning.

"The Harvest Concord Ball," she said, feet up on the windowsill of his room, the slaughterhouse stink drifting in through the cracked glass. "Three nights from now. The Crescent hosts it every autumn: old money, new money, Parliament officials, military brass. Everybody who matters in Veranesse in one room, drinking champagne and pretending the Lowers don't exist."

"That's where the coin is."

"That's where the coin *lives*. These people don't carry purses, Jonah. They carry reputations. The money's in the coatrooms: watches, cufflinks, signet rings, snuff boxes. One good haul from a single coatroom and you're looking at twenty, thirty silvers. Maybe more if someone's stupid enough to leave a billfold."

"Can you get me in?"

Mary snorted. "I can get a rat into a cathedral if the rat holds still long enough. Getting in isn't the problem. *Looking* like you belong is the problem. You walk into the Concord Ball looking like—" She gestured at him, head to toe. "—*this*, and the house guard will have you on the cobblestones before you clear the foyer."

"So I don't look like this."

"No. You don't."

She took him to a man named Ferris.

Ferris operated out of a basement workshop on Chandler's Row, not the good end, the end where the gaslights flickered and the buildings leaned together overhead like drunks sharing a secret. The entrance was a side door marked with a chalk symbol Mary said meant *discreet services*. Inside, it smelled like starch, machine oil, and ambition.

Ferris himself was a wiry little Calleni, five-five on a generous day, with a measuring tape permanently draped around his neck and fingers stained black with dye. He was sixty, maybe older, with a bald head that gleamed like a polished doorknob and wire-rimmed spectacles perched on a nose that had been broken at least twice. He wore a waistcoat that was immaculate, charcoal grey, silk-backed, stitched with the kind of precision that made Jonah's foundry-trained eye twitch with respect. The man's clothes were better than anything in the Crescent. That was the point. He'd been making forgeries of aristocratic fashion for twenty years: suits that looked like they cost a hundred silvers, built from fabric that cost five.

"Arms out," Ferris said, not looking up from his workbench. He had the tape around Jonah's chest before the sentence finished. "Mm. Forty-four. Broad. Soldier?"

"Ironworker."

"Same build, different scars." *Whip-whip-whip* went the measuring tape: shoulders, arms, inseam, neck. Ferris worked like a man defusing a bomb: fast, precise, no wasted motion. "The Concord?"

"Yes," Mary said from the corner, where she was sitting on a crate eating an apple she'd definitely stolen.

"When?"

"Three nights."

Ferris sucked air through his teeth. *Tssss.* "Rush job. Double rate."

"How much?" Jonah asked.

"Eight coppers. Suit, shirt, cravat, and I'll throw in shoes if your feet aren't freakish." He glanced down. "Size eleven. Not freakish. Acceptable."

Eight coppers. That left Jonah nearly broke again, but you couldn't rob the rich dressed like the poor. Investment spending. The economics of crime.

"Do it," he said.

Three nights later, Jonah stood in front of the cracked mirror in his room above the chandler's shop and did not recognize himself.

Ferris was an artist. The suit was midnight blue—not black, because black was common, and common got noticed—with a subtle herringbone weave that caught the light just enough to suggest expense without screaming it. Single-breasted, three-button, cut close through the torso in the continental style that was fashionable among the Crescent's younger set. The fabric wasn't real Harwell wool. It was a Calleni blend, half the cost, twice the durability, but the cut disguised it. The lapels were sharp enough to shave with. The trousers broke cleanly over the borrowed shoes, black leather, polished to a mirror shine with pig fat and prayer.

The shirt was white cotton, high-collared, with a cravat of dark burgundy silk that Ferris had tied for him because Jonah's fingers were built for tongs, not textile origami. Cufflinks: brass, but plated in something that looked like silver from three feet away. A pocket square, folded into a style Ferris called *the Aldworth peak*, which was ironic given that the Aldworth Foundry was the reason Jonah was broke in the first place.

But the suit was only half the work.

Mary had dragged him to a barber on the fourth tier, a legitimate one, not a dockside butcher, and the man had spent forty minutes reshaping Jonah's head. The rough self-hack was gone. His dark hair was now cut short on the sides, longer on top, swept back with pomade that smelled like sandalwood and made him look like a man who owned things. The three-week stubble was trimmed to a precise shadow, not clean-shaven, because the young aristocrats were apparently growing shadow-beards this season, and Jonah's natural stubble fell exactly in the fashionable range.

His jaw looked sharper. His grey eyes looked colder. The burn scars on his knuckles were hidden by a pair of thin leather gloves, grey, kidskin, borrowed from Mary's fence, who was roughly the same hand size.

He looked like money. Not old money. He didn't have the posture for old money, the languid slouch of someone who'd never carried anything heavier than an opinion. He looked like *new* money. Hungry money. The kind of man who'd made his fortune in rail speculation or arms manufacturing and was looking to spend it somewhere impressive.

"Fuck me," Mary said from the doorway, the apple core from earlier still in her hand because she never threw anything away that might be useful. "You actually look like someone."

"I *am* someone."

"You're someone in an eight-copper suit about to rob the most powerful people in Veranesse. Don't get cocky." She tossed him a folded card: heavy cream stock, embossed lettering, the Communion's seal stamped in gold wax. An invitation. "Don't ask where I got it. The name on it is Lord Ashmore Vell. Minor family, old name, no one's seen him in public in two years because he's been in the eastern provinces on a trade commission. You're him tonight."

"And if someone knows what the real Ashmore Vell looks like?"

"Then you're fucked and I'll deny ever meeting you." She smiled. The real one. The one she saved for situations that were either going to go very well or catastrophically wrong. "Have fun, Lord Vell."

The Harvest Concord Ball was held at the Ashburn Estate, a limestone palace at the top of the Crescent that looked like a cathedral had fucked a bank and the offspring had inherited the worst traits of both. Columns, arched windows, copper roof oxidized to pale green, gaslight blazing from every surface until the whole building glowed against the night sky like a lantern for rich moths.

The gates were wrought iron, twelve feet high, and worked into the center of each one—silvered, catching the gaslight—was a single leaf. Finely veined. Delicate as frost.

Jonah's step hitched. Half a beat. Nobody noticed.

He'd seen that leaf before. Three nights ago. Pinned to the collar of a Khett slaver, in a sewer, a foot from a girl in a cage.

Clip-clop-clip-clop. Carriages lined the circular drive, black lacquered wood and brass fittings, drawn by horses that were better fed than anyone in the Lowers. Footmen in livery opened doors. Women in silk and men in wool flowed up the marble steps in a perfumed river of entitlement.

Jonah joined the current.

His heart was hammering—*thud-thud-thud-thud*—fast enough that he could feel it in his fingertips inside the borrowed gloves. He kept his face

neutral. His posture straight but not stiff. He held the invitation card loosely, the way a man holds something he's held a hundred times before.

The door steward, a rigid specimen in a black tailcoat with a face like a disappointed hatchet, took the card, glanced at it, glanced at Jonah, and nodded.

"Lord Vell. Welcome back to Veranesse."

"Good to be back," Jonah said, and walked into the mouth of the beast.

The ballroom was enormous. A hundred feet long, fifty wide, with a vaulted ceiling painted in murals of the Revolution: Liberty Leading the Communion, all flowing robes and righteous fury, which was deeply ironic given that the people under that ceiling had done everything possible to ensure Liberty led from a comfortable distance. Crystal chandeliers hung in rows, each one blazing with a hundred candles, throwing prismatic light across the marble floor. An orchestra occupied a raised platform at the far end—strings, brass, a harpsichord—playing something elegant and utterly forgettable. The air smelled like beeswax, champagne, and money.

Jonah took a glass from a passing tray. Sipped. The champagne was cold, dry, and better than anything he'd ever tasted. He tried not to look like a man tasting good champagne for the first time.

He scanned the room. Mapped it. The coatrooms would be off the main foyer. He'd clocked two doors flanking the entrance, both staffed by attendants. The trick would be getting in alone. He needed a distraction, or a window when the attendants were pulled elsewhere. The dancing would help. When the formal dances started, the staff thinned out to serve the floor. That was his window. Maybe twenty minutes.

He was running the angles—timing, exits, what he could carry without bulging the suit—when the crowd near the grand staircase shifted, and his planning stopped.

She came down the stairs like the building had been built for this specific moment.

Jess—though he didn't know her name yet, wouldn't for another forty minutes—was tall. Five-seven, five-eight. The kind of tall that women either apologize for or weaponize, and she had clearly chosen the latter. She wore a gown of deep emerald silk that fit her body the way water fits a glass: poured on, clinging everywhere it was supposed to, flowing everywhere else. The neckline plunged in a sharp V that stopped just above the navel, held in place

by what Jonah could only assume was architectural engineering and sheer aristocratic willpower. Her breasts were pushed up and together by the structure of the bodice—full, pale, the kind that made you forget what you were saying mid-sentence—and the candlelight from the chandeliers caught the dusting of freckles across her collarbone like scattered copper.

Her hair was auburn, darker than Mary's, richer, the color of mahogany, swept up in an elaborate arrangement that left her neck bare. Long neck. The kind of neck that portrait painters lost sleep over. Diamond earrings caught the light as she turned her head. Her face was—refined. That was the word. High cheekbones, straight nose, a jaw that was delicate but not weak. Full lips, painted dark red, set in an expression of cultivated boredom that only the truly wealthy could afford to wear. Her eyes were dark blue—navy, almost—wide-set, intelligent, scanning the room with the practiced disinterest of a woman who had been looked at her entire life and had learned to control exactly what people saw when they looked.

She was flanked by two older women in similar finery—mother and aunt, maybe, or chaperones—and trailed by a man in military dress who was either a suitor or a bodyguard. She ignored all of them with the effortless cruelty of someone who'd been ignoring people since birth.

She was the most beautiful woman Jonah had ever seen, and he hated her immediately. Hated her because she was everything the Crescent was: polished, pristine, untouched by the grime and the hunger and the stink that defined everything below the rail line. Hated her because the emerald silk she wore cost more than he'd earn in a year on the docks. Hated her because she was looking out over the ballroom with those dark blue eyes and seeing exactly nothing worth her attention, and he was standing in a borrowed suit with another man's name in his pocket, planning to rob her kind blind.

And hated her most of all because his cock stirred in the perfectly tailored Calleni-blend trousers, and the timing was phenomenally fucking inconvenient.

She reached the bottom of the staircase. The crowd parted for her. Not consciously. Nobody stepped aside with visible deference, but the space opened around her the way space opens around heat. She took a glass of champagne from a tray without looking at the servant holding it, brought it to those dark red lips, sipped, and her eyes swept the room one more time.

They landed on Jonah.

Not a glance. A *stop*. The sweep halted, reversed, came back to him, and held. Two seconds. Three. Long enough that the older woman beside her—the mother, definitely the mother, same bone structure, same imperious jaw, twenty years and several disappointments further along—noticed the pause and followed her daughter's gaze to the tall, dark-haired man in the midnight blue suit standing alone near the east colonnade with a champagne glass in his gloved hand and an expression that said absolutely nothing.

Jess didn't smile. Didn't nod. Didn't do any of the things a well-bred woman was supposed to do when she caught a stranger's eye across a ballroom. She just *looked*, direct, unblinking, with the faintest narrowing of those navy eyes that might have been curiosity or might have been the first warning sign of something far more dangerous.

Then she turned away, said something to the military man that made him straighten, and walked toward the far side of the ballroom, the emerald silk catching the chandelier light in ripples of green and gold, her bare back straight as a blade.

Jonah drained his champagne. Set the glass on the nearest surface.

The coatrooms could wait.

He straightened the borrowed cravat, adjusted the counterfeit cufflinks, and walked into the crowd after her—a wolf in Calleni wool, eight coppers of forgery between him and exposure, with a hundred and fifty silvers to steal and a name that wasn't his and the lingering, inconvenient, absolutely unhelpful image of dark blue eyes and freckled collarbone burning in the front of his skull like a brand.

The orchestra swelled into a waltz. The chandeliers blazed. And Jonah Wren—*Lord Ashmore Vell*—crossed the marble floor toward the most dangerous woman in the room with the dim awareness that he was no longer entirely sure what he was there to steal.

He tracked her through the crowd like a man following a lantern in fog. She moved through the ballroom with the particular fluidity of someone who'd been trained to move through rooms: spine straight, chin level, shoulders back, every step calibrated to project the impression that she was going somewhere important and you were not invited. The emerald gown trailed

behind her in a whisper of silk. Men watched her pass. She didn't notice, or didn't care, which amounted to the same thing.

She bypassed the dance floor, declined a conversation with a red-faced general who looked like an overstuffed sausage in a medal collection, exchanged three words with the military man trailing her, something clipped and dismissive that made him stop walking and stand there like a dog told to stay, and then slipped through a set of glass doors onto the upper balcony.

Jonah gave it thirty seconds. Counted it off in his head. Then followed.

The balcony wrapped around the east wing of the Ashburn Estate, overlooking the formal gardens below where the party had spilled outdoors, lanterns strung between the hedgerows, guests drifting along gravel paths, the orchestra faintly audible through the glass. The air up here was cooler, sharper, carrying the scent of late roses and coal smoke from the rail yards far below. You could see the whole city from this height: the Crescent glowing warm and golden at the top, the merchant quarter's redbrick and iron beneath it, and then the Lowers, spreading dark and shapeless toward the waterfront like a stain the city was trying to pretend wasn't there.

She was standing at the stone balustrade, champagne glass in one hand, looking down at the gardens. Alone. The candlelight from inside caught the bare skin of her back. The gown was cut low, scooping to the base of her spine, and the freckles across her shoulder blades looked like a constellation he didn't know the name of.

Jonah adjusted his cravat. Straightened his spine. Summoned every scrap of overheard aristocratic conversation he'd absorbed during three days of dock work next to merchants who talked too loudly.

"Lovely evening for a—a convocation of—the seasonal..." He trailed off. The sentence had started wrong and gotten worse, like a cart losing a wheel on a downhill slope.

She turned her head. Just her head. The rest of her body stayed perfectly still, angled toward the gardens, as if only a fraction of her attention was worth spending on whoever had just walked out here and butchered the Common tongue.

Those navy eyes. Up close, they were worse. Darker than he'd thought, with flecks of grey near the iris that made them look like deep water over stone. They settled on him with the precise, unhurried focus of someone examining an insect that had landed on their sleeve.

"I'm sorry," she said. "A convocation of *what*?"

"Of—the gentry. The assembled. You know." He gestured vaguely at the gardens below, where a woman in a yellow dress was laughing too loudly while a man poured champagne and missed the glass. "All this."

"All *this*," she repeated. The words came back at him flattened, clinical, like a doctor repeating a symptom. "Are you attempting conversation, or are you having a medical episode?"

"Conversation. Attempting. Yes."

"You're quite bad at it."

"So I've been told."

She turned fully now, leaning one hip against the balustrade, and looked at him the way Ferris had looked at his measurements, assessing raw material, calculating what could be made from it. The champagne glass dangled from her fingers at her side, forgotten.

"I don't know you," she said.

"Lord Ashmore Vell."

"No you're not."

Jonah's stomach dropped about six inches. "I—"

"Ashmore Vell is fifty-three years old, five foot six, and has a birthmark shaped like the Brevish Isles across his left cheek. You are none of those things." She took a sip of champagne without breaking eye contact. "So. Who are you actually, and why are you on this balcony speaking to me as though you learned social graces from an instruction pamphlet?"

Fuck.

The smart play was to leave. Apologize, mutter something about a misunderstanding, walk back through the glass doors, find a coatroom, and execute the plan. That was the smart play. Jonah had never been accused of making smart plays.

"Jonah," he said. "Jonah Wren."

"That's not a Crescent name."

"Because I'm not from the Crescent."

"Obviously." She tilted her head. The diamond earrings caught the light and threw tiny rainbows across the stone behind her. "The Lowers? The docks?"

"Originally, Aldworth. The foundry district. Now—yeah. The docks."

Something shifted in her expression. Not softening—women like this didn't soften, they recalibrated—but a flicker of something that might have been interest. The way a cat's ear twitches toward an unfamiliar sound. Not alarmed. Not yet. Just... noting it.

"A dockworker in a suit that's pretending to be Harwell wool but isn't," she said, "carrying a forged invitation under a stolen name, at the most exclusive event of the social season." She raised the champagne glass to her lips again. "You're either very brave or catastrophically stupid."

"I've been told those are the same thing."

"They're not. Brave men know what they're risking. Stupid men don't realize there's a risk." She studied him over the rim of the glass. "Which are you?"

"Depends on what happens in the next five minutes."

"That's the first interesting thing you've said."

They looked at each other. The orchestra drifted through the glass doors behind them—something slower now, a waltz winding down into its final movement. Below, the garden party murmured. A woman laughed. A cork popped. *Fffsht.* The gaslights along the balustrade hissed softly, their flames dancing in the breeze.

She was close enough that he could smell her perfume, not the heavy floral assault most of the women inside were wearing, but something lighter, sharper. Citrus and cedar and something warm underneath, like skin that had been in the sun. Close enough that he could see the faint pulse in her throat, just above the collarbone, and the way her chest rose and fell with each breath, the emerald silk shifting over her breasts like water disturbed by a stone beneath the surface.

He wanted to touch her. The wanting was so immediate and so specific that it startled him. Not the generalized hunger he'd taken to Lina, not the animal need of three months at sea, but something pointed. He wanted to put his thumb on that pulse point in her throat and feel her heartbeat. He wanted to know if her skin was as warm as it looked.

He didn't move. Couldn't. There was a wall between them, not physical, not even social, but something more fundamental. She was looking at him from the other side of a distance that had nothing to do with the three feet of balcony stone between them and everything to do with the thousand invisible gradients of birth and money and name that separated a man who hauled

crates from a woman who wore diamonds. He could feel it like a change in air pressure. She could too. He saw it in the way her fingers tightened fractionally on the champagne glass, the way her weight shifted backward by a centimeter —not retreating, not exactly, but *holding position*. Maintaining the line.

"You should leave," she said. Quietly. Not a command. A warning. The kind a lighthouse gives.

"Probably."

"If anyone finds out you're not Vell—"

"I know."

"Do you? Because the penalty for impersonating a Lord of the Communion isn't a fine, Mr. Wren. It's the Greystone. Five years. Minimum."

"I said I know."

"Then *why* are you still standing here?"

He opened his mouth. Didn't have an answer. Closed it. She watched him not answer and something—frustration, maybe, or something adjacent to it, something with a different temperature—passed behind those navy eyes like a shadow under ice.

"Jessamine," a voice said behind them. "There you are."

They both turned. The military man from earlier stood in the doorway, tall, square-jawed, blond hair oiled back, dress uniform buttoned to the throat and hung with enough brass to furnish a shop. He had the particular expression of a man who has been looking for a woman he considers his property and has found her speaking to someone he does not recognize.

"Captain Aldric Thorne," Jess said, and her voice had changed: the curiosity was gone, replaced by something polished and impenetrable, a door slamming shut so smoothly you wouldn't know it had been open. "May I introduce Lord Ashmore Vell. Recently returned from the eastern provinces."

Thorne looked at Jonah the way a dog looks at another dog near its bowl. Jonah looked back with no expression at all.

"Lord Vell." Thorne's tone could have frosted glass. "I don't believe we've met."

"We haven't," Jonah said. "Pleasure."

It was not a pleasure. Everyone on the balcony knew it was not a pleasure. The word hung in the air like a held breath.

"Jessamine, your mother is asking for you. The Hargrieve introduction." Thorne extended his arm. Not an invitation. A retrieval.

Jess looked at Jonah one more time. A half-second. Those dark blue eyes carrying a sentence she didn't say—*go, you idiot, before this gets worse*—and then she took Thorne's arm and let herself be steered back through the glass doors into the light and the noise and the world where she belonged and he did not.

The doors closed. The balcony was empty. The orchestra started a new piece, something bright and celebratory, and Jonah stood alone above the gardens with the ghost of cedar perfume in his nose and his hands gripping the stone balustrade hard enough to whiten the borrowed gloves.

Focus.

He breathed. Let the thing in his chest, whatever it was, whatever she'd stirred up, settle. Pushed it down beneath the operational layer of his brain where the plan lived, where the numbers lived, where a hundred and fifty silvers lived in the form of a girl in a cage with amber eyes.

The coatroom. Now. While the waltz was pulling bodies onto the dance floor and the staff was busy pouring champagne.

He went back inside. The crowd had thickened. The dancing had drawn people toward the center of the ballroom like a current, leaving the periphery thin. He moved along the east wall, close to the colonnade, walking with the unhurried confidence of a man heading to the lavatory. Nobody looked at him. The suit did its work. Ferris earned his eight coppers ten times over.

The coatroom was through a service corridor off the main foyer: a heavy oak door, unlocked, the attendant nowhere in sight because he'd been pulled to serve the champagne station. Jonah slipped inside and closed the door and the noise of the ball dropped to a murmur.

Rows of coats. Dozens. Fur-lined cloaks, wool greatcoats, a velvet opera cape that probably cost more than the chandler's shop. He worked fast, systematic. Gloves off, fingers quick. Inside pockets first. That's where the real items lived. A silver cigarette case, heavy, engraved. *Pocket.* A gold pocket watch on a chain, the back inscribed with initials he didn't read. *Pocket.* A leather billfold. He flipped it open, counted: four silver notes, two gold. *Christ.* Into the inner breast pocket of the midnight blue suit. A snuff box, enameled, possibly worth more than anything else in the room. *Pocket.* A signet ring left carelessly in a coat lining, old gold, fat stone, family crest. *Pocket.*

Ninety seconds. Maybe less. His heart was steady. His hands were steady. This wasn't his first theft—the Reclamation had taught everyone to take what they needed—but it was his first theft from people who could afford to lose it, and there was a specific pleasure in that, a grim satisfaction that sat in his chest like a warm coal.

He checked himself in the small mirror on the coatroom wall. The suit hung clean: no bulges, no tells. Ferris had built the jacket with deep interior pockets, lined with silk to prevent clinking. The man was a genius. A criminal genius, but a genius nonetheless.

Jonah smoothed the cravat. Adjusted the pocket square. Opened the door, stepped back into the service corridor, and walked toward the foyer with the calm, measured stride of Lord Ashmore Vell, recently returned from the eastern provinces, who had attended a lovely ball and was now departing because he had early business in the morning.

He made it to the foot of the grand staircase before he felt it: that prickle at the back of the neck, the animal sense of being looked at.

He glanced up.

The gallery. Above the foyer, half in shadow behind a marble balustrade, a flash of emerald silk. Jessamine. Alone, for once—no mother, no captain—one gloved hand resting on the stone, the other holding a fresh glass of champagne. She was looking straight down at him. At the service corridor behind him. At the door he'd just come out of.

She knew. He saw her know. The math was right there on her face—*the coatroom, the timing, the dockworker in the borrowed name*—and he waited for her to turn and call for the house guard.

She didn't.

She raised the champagne glass. A fraction of an inch. Barely a toast. And then she turned and walked back into the light of the ballroom, and the emerald silk was gone, and the gallery was empty.

Jonah stood very still for one heartbeat. Then he kept walking, because there was nothing else to do, and because the thing crawling up the back of his neck wasn't relief.

She'd let him go. Women like that didn't let anything go for free.

The door steward nodded. The night air hit his face. The carriages waited in the drive.

He walked past them. Down the marble steps. Through the gates of the Ashburn Estate. Down the winding road of the Crescent, past the limestone facades and the copper roofs, past the gaslit gardens and the iron railings, down through the merchant quarter where the redbrick closed in and the rail trestles rattled overhead, down into the Lowers where the air thickened and the lights dimmed and the city became the city he actually knew.

He loosened the cravat as he walked. Unbuttoned the top of the shirt. The night air was warm and smelled like coal and the harbor and the particular funk of the Lowers at rest. His pockets were heavy. His chest was tight with something he refused to examine.

Jessamine.

He said it once, under his breath, to nobody. Tasted it the way Lina had tasted his name. Then he put it away, in the same locked compartment where he kept every other thing he wanted and couldn't have, and walked faster toward Bent Street, where Mary would be waiting with the gin and the questions and the math of turning stolen silver into a girl in an iron cage who needed saving more than he needed whatever had just happened on that balcony.

His boots hit the cobblestones in a hard, fast rhythm—*tak-tak-tak-tak*—and the city swallowed the sound the way it swallowed everything.

Chapter Five

The Purchase



Mary had the gin out before he cleared the doorway.

She was sitting cross-legged on his mattress, boots off, feet bare and dirty, that man's shirt hanging off one shoulder, with the bottle between her knees and two clay cups lined up on the floor like soldiers waiting for orders. She'd lit a candle. The room smelled like tallow and slaughterhouse and the faint sweetness of the gin, which was not the turpentine stuff this time but something amber and halfway decent that she'd acquired from somewhere she wouldn't explain.

"Well?" she said.

Jonah emptied his pockets onto the mattress.

The cigarette case. The pocket watch. The billfold: four silvers, two golds. The snuff box. The signet ring.

Mary stared at the pile. Her mouth opened. Closed. Opened again.

"You absolute mad *bastard*."

"Pour the drinks."

She poured. They drank. The gin was warm and smooth and burned in exactly the right way, not the throat-scraping punishment of cheap dock liquor but something that actually tasted like it was made by someone who gave a shit about juniper.

"The watch alone is worth ten silvers," Mary said, turning it over in her fingers, the candlelight catching the gold. "The ring—depends on the stone,

but eight, maybe twelve. The cigarette case, three to five. The billfold, obviously, that's straight coin. The snuff box..." She held it up, squinting at the enamel work: a pastoral scene, shepherds and sheep, painted in tiny brushstrokes on a lacquered lid. "Fifteen. Maybe twenty if I take it to the right buyer. Jonah, this is—" She did the math. Her eyes widened. "This is forty silvers. Minimum. Maybe fifty."

"I need a hundred and fifty."

"What?"

"The cat-girl. In the Underbelly. The Khett wants fifteen silvers. I need one-fifty in coppers, or fifteen in silver. I've got enough."

Mary set the snuff box down carefully, like it might explode. "You're telling me you robbed the Harvest Concord Ball—the single most insane, suicidal, brilliant piece of thievery I have ever been adjacent to—for a *Felinara*?"

"Yes."

"A Felinara you've met once. Who was in a cage. Who you know nothing about."

"She bites, apparently."

"Jonah."

"Mary."

They looked at each other across the candle flame. Mary's green eyes were doing that thing, the calculation, the odds-running, the quiet machinery of a mind that had survived the Lowers since childhood by being smarter than everyone around her.

"You're not telling me everything," she said.

"I'm telling you what matters."

"No, you're telling me about the cat-girl, which matters, fine, I get it, you've got a savior complex the size of the harbor. But you're not looking at me when you talk, and you keep touching your cravat like it's strangling you, and your jaw's doing that thing it does when you're chewing on something you don't want to say." She leaned forward. "Who did you meet at the ball?"

"Nobody."

"*Jonah.*"

"Nobody relevant to the plan."

"Everything's relevant to the plan if it's rattling around in your thick skull and distracting you from—" She stopped. Read his face. The candlelight

flickered. Her expression changed: a slow, incredulous dawning, like watching the sun rise over a garbage heap. "Oh no. No. You did *not*."

"I didn't do anything."

"You met a woman. A Crescent woman. A *noble* woman." Mary threw her head back and laughed, not the ghost-smile, not the smirk, but a full-throated, head-back, barking laugh that shook her narrow frame. "*Hhhaaa!* You walked into the most dangerous building in Veranesse, robbed them blind, and caught *feelings*? On the *job*?"

"I didn't catch anything. We talked for two minutes."

"Two minutes. Two minutes and you look like someone hit you with a church bell." She was grinning now, the full devastating grin of Mary Grieve who had found something she was never, ever going to let you forget. "What's her name?"

"I'm not discussing this."

"What's her *name*, Jonah?"

"Jessamine."

Mary fell backward onto the mattress, laughing so hard the gin sloshed in the bottle. "JESSAMINE! Of course it is! Not Jenny, not Meg, not something from the actual world—*Jessamine*, like a fucking flower pressed in a book. You monumental, irredeemable *idiot*."

"Are you done?"

"Not even close." She sat back up, wiping her eyes. "But I'll table it. Because right now you've got fifty silvers' worth of stolen property on this mattress and a purchase to make before your cat-girl gets sold to whatever creep was bidding against you. So, business first, mockery after."

She was right. She was always right. He hated that about her.

Mary moved the goods in three hours.

Jonah didn't ask how. Didn't ask who. She left with the pile and came back with a leather pouch that clinked heavy with silver, twenty-two silvers, after her cut, which she took without discussion because Mary Grieve did not work for free and anyone who expected her to had never met her.

She came back with something else, too. She tossed the pouch on the mattress and leaned in the doorway with the smug, glittering patience of a cat who'd brought home a bird.

"Your flower," she said. "Jessamine. The fence knew the snuff box. It's a famous little piece, apparently, which is why I got eighteen for it and not twenty. Came out of the Ashburn coatroom." She let it sit. "Jessamine *Ashburn*, Jonah. Only daughter. It's her house. You robbed her house, at her party, and then went out on her balcony and made eyes at her."

He thought of the gallery. The raised glass. The fraction-of-an-inch toast.

He thought of the silver leaf on the gates.

"Mary. The Ashburns. What's their crest?"

She frowned. "An ash leaf. Silver. Why?"

He didn't answer. He picked up the pouch and felt its weight, and for the first time since the balcony the warm, stupid thing in his chest went cold.

Twenty-two silvers. More money than Jonah had held in his life. More than enough for the Khett.

He went to the Underbelly alone. Mary offered to come. He said no. She called him an idiot again, her third-favorite word, after *copper* and *mine*, and let him go.

The storm drain. The brick tunnel. The dripping dark. *Drip. Drip. Drip.* Left channel. Lanterns. The cistern opened up around him like the belly of a stone whale, and the market was thinner tonight, fewer vendors, fewer buyers, the weapons stalls half-packed, the air thick with smoke from a brazier someone had lit in the corner.

The Khett with the sheet-music scars was still at the rope line. He looked at Jonah the way a shopkeeper looks at a customer who might actually have money this time.

"Back," the Khett said. Not a question.

"Fifteen silvers." Jonah held up the pouch. Shook it. The coins sang inside the leather, *chink-chink-chink*, the universal language of transaction.

The Khett took the pouch, opened it, counted. His scarred fingers were fast and precise. He bit one coin, checked the edge, nodded.

"She's yours. Hold still."

He walked to the third cage, produced a key from a chain around his neck, and unlocked the iron door. It swung open with a *screeeeee* that set Jonah's teeth on edge.

The girl inside didn't move.

She was exactly as he remembered: small, copper-haired, ears flat, amber eyes burning in the lamplight with pupils contracted to black slits. She was crouched in the back of the cage, tail wrapped tight around her ankles, and she was watching the open door the way a cornered animal watches an exit that might be a trap.

"Out," the Khett said. "You're bought."

She came out slowly. Not compliant—cautious. Each step deliberate, her bare feet silent on the stone, her weight balanced on the balls of her feet like she was ready to bolt. She stood up straight for the first time and she was exactly as small as he'd estimated: five-two, barely, with a frame that was all wire and sinew and the particular leanness of someone who had been underfed for a long time. The rough-spun shift hung on her like a sack. Her legs were scratched. Her feet were filthy. Her hands—small, human-looking except for the nails, which curved faintly to points—were clenched at her sides.

She looked at Jonah. Up at him. She barely reached his chest. Those amber eyes, huge in her angular face, the slit pupils widening in the dim light until they were almost round.

"This one?" she said. Her voice was higher than he'd expected, not small, not meek, but sharp and thin, like a blade that hadn't been sharpened but could still cut. "This is the one buying me?"

"This is him," the Khett confirmed. "Transaction's done. He's your master now. Try not to bite this one."

"No promises." She showed her teeth. They were—mostly human. Canines slightly longer, slightly sharper. The kind of detail you wouldn't notice unless she wanted you to, and right now, she very much wanted him to.

The Khett walked away. Transaction complete. Merchandise transferred. Nothing personal.

Jonah looked at her. She looked at Jonah. The lamplight guttered between them.

"Right," he said. "Let's go."

"Go *where*?"

"My room. I've got a place on Bent Street—"

"Your *room*." Her ears flattened so hard they practically disappeared into her hair. Her tail puffed—actually puffed, the fur bristling along its length—and she took a step backward. "Absolutely not. You buy me from a cage and

the first thing out of your mouth is *let's go back to my room*? Do I look stupid to you?"

"I didn't mean—"

"I know what you *meant*. Every man who buys a Felinara *means* the same thing. Take her home, use her up, throw her out when you're bored. Or keep her chained to the bed for whenever you get the urge. I've heard the stories. My mother told me before she—" She stopped. Something hard crossed her face, like a door slamming. "I'm not your fuck-toy, human."

"I don't want a fuck-toy."

"Oh *wonderful*, he wants a maid! Even better! Should I scrub your floors on my hands and knees? Cook your meals? Wash your shit-stained smallclothes? What a *tremendous* upgrade from the cage, truly, I'm *overwhelmed* with gratitude—"

"Would you *stop*—"

"Or maybe you want the exotic experience. That's the popular one. Never had a cat-blood before, want to see if the stories are true, do we *purr*, are we flexible, is it different *down there*—"

"*Jesus Christ.* I'm trying to *free* you—"

She stopped. Blinked. Her ears came up half an inch, an involuntary twitch, like a signal she hadn't meant to send.

"What?"

"I'm trying to free you. That's—that's the whole point. I'm not—I don't —" He ran his hand over his face. "I grew up in Aldworth. The foundry district. I watched the Levellers burn it to the ground because the masters wouldn't free the indentured workers. Good men, chained to anvils for debts their *grandfathers* owed. I don't—" He felt his voice getting hot, felt the old anger climbing up his throat like bile. "I don't keep people. Not humans. Not beast-kin. Not anyone. The Communion says you're free but the Communion is full of shit, so I bought you because that was the only way to get you out of that cage before some Crescent pervert turned you into a house pet. You're free. That's it. Walk away right now if you want. I won't follow you."

Silence. The brazier crackled. Somewhere in the cistern, a vendor was arguing with a buyer in Khett, their voices echoing off the domed ceiling.

The girl stared at him. Those enormous amber eyes, slit pupils dilating and contracting as she processed: not just his words but his face, his posture, his

scent probably, because Felinara could smell things humans couldn't, and whatever she smelled, it made her head tilt sideways the way a cat's does when it encounters something genuinely novel.

"You spent fifteen silvers," she said slowly, "to free a Felinara you don't know."

"Yes."

"Fifteen silvers. That you clearly don't have, because you smell like the docks and your coat has been patched twice and your boots are rotting at the soles."

"I stole the money, if that helps."

"It does, actually. Proves you're stupid enough to be telling the truth. No one *smart* enough to steal fifteen silvers would be dumb enough to spend it on a stranger."

"So you believe me?"

"I believe you're either honest or the most committed pervert in Veranesse. Either way—" She looked around the cistern. At the cages. At the Khett guards. At the tunnel entrance. At her own bare, dirty feet on the cold stone. "Either way, I'm not staying down here."

"So come with me. I've got a room. It smells like a slaughterhouse because there's a slaughterhouse behind it, and the mattress is straw, and I can't promise food tonight but I can promise nobody's going to put you in a cage."

"You're setting the bar extraordinarily low."

"I'm aware."

She chewed the inside of her cheek. Her tail had stopped puffing. The fur lay flat again, though it still twitched at the tip in an irritated rhythm, *flick-flick-flick*, like a metronome counting down to a decision.

"Fine," she said. "But I'm sleeping by the door. And if you touch me in the night, I'll take your eyes out. I'm not being figurative. I will physically remove your eyeballs from your skull."

"Understood."

"And I want food. Real food. Not fish guts or dock stew or whatever garbage you've been eating."

"I'll see what I can do."

"And a blanket."

"I have one blanket."

"Then I'm taking it."

"Of course you are."

She walked past him toward the tunnel entrance, bare feet slapping the stone, *pat-pat-pat-pat*, and he fell into step behind her because apparently that was his role now, following small angry women through dark spaces. Her ears swiveled backward, tracking him, making sure he stayed behind her and not beside her and certainly not in front of her. Her tail swished low behind her, the dark tip flicking back and forth with every step.

"What's your name?" he asked her back.

"What's it to you?"

"I just spent fifteen silvers on you. I'd like to know what to call you."

She glanced over her shoulder. Those amber eyes, catching the lantern light and throwing it back at him in bright coins of reflected gold.

"Sable," she said. "And you didn't spend fifteen silvers *on* me. You spent fifteen silvers on your own conscience. There's a difference."

She started to turn away—then stopped. Her nose twitched. Twice, quick, the way a cat tests the air when something on the wind doesn't belong. She stepped back toward him, close, closer than she'd let him get since the cage, and breathed in near his collar.

Her ears went flat.

"You've been up the hill," she said. Her voice had changed. Lower. Careful. "Under the docks and the sweat. Cedar oil. Orange peel. Rich-house soap, the kind they wash the linens in so the whole house smells like money." She looked up at him, and the slit pupils had gone thin as knife edges. "The man who came down here to look at me smelled exactly like that. He's the one who left the deposit. He walked all the way around my cage twice and didn't say a word to me. Just looked. Like I was a horse."

The silver leaf on a Khett collar. The silver leaf on the gates.

"The Ashburns," Jonah said.

"I don't know names. I know smells." She held his eyes a moment longer, measuring something. Then she turned. "Wash that off before you sleep near me."

She walked on, and Jonah followed her through the dripping tunnel and up through the rusted grate and out into the Veranesse night, where the stars hung cold and the rail trestles hummed overhead and the city sprawled dark and indifferent below them, and he was suddenly aware, in the bone-deep, un-

ignorable way you become aware of weather changing, that his life had just gotten significantly more complicated.

Sable walked ahead, barefoot, thin, ears twitching at every sound, tail low, chin up, heading toward Bent Street like she already owned it.

He still had seven silvers left. Rent was covered. Food could be managed. Work started at dawn.

Three women in his orbit now—a thief, a noble, and a Felinara with a mouth like a razor and claws to match—and he was broke again, exhausted, and standing in the dark outside a tannery at one in the morning with absolutely no plan for what came next.

The squeeze-box from the Burnt Rose drifted faintly up from the waterfront, wheezing its drunken waltz into the salt air.

Jonah adjusted the eight-copper suit that had already paid for itself ten times over, and walked home.

Chapter Six

Storm Country



The job was supposed to be simple. Mary's word, not his. *Simple.*

A cargo intercept on the northern rail line: a shipment of Khett silk coming down from the mountain passes, rerouted through a switching station twelve miles outside Veranesse where the security was light and the terrain was dense forest. Mary had a buyer. Jonah had the muscle. Get in, crack the cargo hold, take four bolts of silk worth six silvers each, disappear into the treeline before the next rail-coach passed.

Simple.

Except it wasn't really about the silk. Mary had said as much on the walk out, picking her way through the bracken with that quick, sour economy she brought to everything. The job came from Marks, Marks the Big, who ran the south docks and had sized Jonah up across a gin-house table on day four without saying more than a dozen words. Six silvers a bolt was pocket change to Marks. This was an audition.

"Do it clean," she'd told him, "and there's a bigger job behind it. A *much* bigger job."

"How much bigger?"

"He calls it the Meridian." She hadn't looked at him when she said it. "That's all he'll say until he's sure of you."

So: the silk, and the audition, and the Meridian waiting behind both like a door at the end of a hall.

They were in the bracken an hour before Jonah noticed the station was wrong.

He was on his stomach in the wet fern, watching the switching house through a gap in the brush: a squat brick shed, a signal tower, a water tank on iron legs, the twin rails curving away north into the trees. Mary had said two guards. Bored ones. Communion rail militia, half-asleep on a posting nobody wanted.

He counted six.

Not bored, either. Rifles held properly, not slung. Two on the signal tower with a clear sightline down the track. One by the water tank, smoking with his back to a pillar so nobody could come up behind him. Their eyes kept going to the treeline. To exactly the stretch of treeline where a pair of thieves would lie up if they'd been told where to lie up.

He touched Mary's elbow. Pointed with his chin.

She looked. He watched her count, lips moving, *four, five, six*, and watched the color go out of her face.

"That's not a posting," she breathed. "That's a welcome party."

"Someone sold the job."

"Nobody knew about the job. Me. You. Marks. The buyer." Her jaw tightened. Her eyes went somewhere else for a second, somewhere far off and ugly, and came back. "*Fuck.*"

"Mary. Who else knew?"

She didn't answer. Above them the light was going strange: yellow, then brown, the air suddenly heavy and still, the birds gone quiet all at once.

What Mary hadn't accounted for—what nobody had accounted for, because the weather service in Veranesse was about as reliable as a drunk compass—was the storm.

It came out of the northwest like God had a grudge. One minute they were crouched in the bracken beside the switching station, watching six rifles watch the trees. The next, the sky was black as a bruise from horizon to horizon and the wind was shaking the trees so hard the branches sounded like bones breaking. *CRACK. CRACK. CRACK.* Then the rain. Not rain, not really, more like the ocean had been picked up and dropped sideways: sheets of water so dense you couldn't see ten feet, hammering the canopy above them in a roar that swallowed every other sound.

"WE NEED TO MOVE!" Mary screamed, two feet from his ear, and he could barely hear her.

They ran. The forest floor turned to mud inside of ninety seconds, sucking at their boots with every step, and the rain hit so hard it stung, like being slapped by something cold and endless and furious. Lightning split the sky—*KRRACK*—close enough that the thunder didn't follow, it *arrived*, simultaneous, a wall of sound that shook his ribs.

Mary had a tent. Because Mary had everything. She pulled it from her pack: a small canvas thing, military surplus, barely big enough for one person, certainly not designed for two. And they wrestled it up between three trees, driving the stakes into mud that didn't want to hold anything, the canvas flapping and snapping like a living thing trying to escape.

They crawled inside. Soaked. Both of them. Drenched to the fucking marrow, shaking, gasping, lying on their sides in a space roughly the size of a coffin built for a child.

PATTER-PATTER-PATTER-PATTER—the rain on the canvas, inches above their faces. The wind howled. The trees groaned. Lightning strobed through the fabric in white flashes that turned everything into a series of frozen photographs: Mary's face, close, wet, her dark auburn hair plastered to her skull, those green eyes wide and bright.

"Simple," Jonah said. "You said simple."

"Shut up."

"You said—and I'm quoting—*it's a milk run, Jonah, we'll be back before dark*—"

"I said *shut up*." She was shivering. They both were. The temperature had dropped twenty degrees in the space of an hour, and they were lying in soaked clothes in an uninsulated canvas tent in what was rapidly becoming the worst storm Jonah had experienced outside of the Atlantic crossing.

"We need to get these clothes off," he said.

"Absolutely fucking not."

"Mary. We're soaked. The temperature's dropping. If we stay in wet clothing we're going to get hypothermic and die in a tent twelve miles from the city and nobody will find us until the wolves do."

"There aren't wolves this close to Veranesse."

"There are *definitely* wolves this close to Veranesse."

She glared at him. The lightning flashed again—*KRRACK*—and in the strobe he saw her jaw working, her teeth chattering, the gooseflesh running down her neck and disappearing into the soaked collar of the oversized man's shirt.

"Fine," she said. "Turn around."

"Mary, we're in a tent the size of a pillowcase. There is no *around* to turn."

"Then close your eyes."

"It's pitch dark."

"Then—*fuck*—just—don't look."

He didn't look. He didn't need to. The tent was so small that he could feel everything: the movement of her arms as she peeled the wet shirt over her head, the shift of her weight as she shimmied out of the leather corset, the brief brush of bare skin against his forearm that sent a jolt through him like he'd touched a hot stove. He stripped his own shirt off, wrung it out as best he could, laid it flat. His trousers were a lost cause, soaked through, and after a moment's grim arithmetic, he pulled those off too.

They lay there in the dark. Side by side. Both of them stripped to smallclothes that were as wet as everything else and therefore essentially decorative. The canvas pressed down from above. The rain hammered. The wind moaned through the trees like something wounded.

Her shoulder was touching his. He could feel her shivering: fast, involuntary tremors running through her frame. She was thin. He'd always known she was thin, but knowing and *feeling* were different, and what he felt now—the sharp angle of her shoulder blade, the narrow ridge of her collarbone, the concavity of her stomach where her ribs showed—was a woman who had been hungry more often than not for a very long time.

"Come here," he said.

"No."

"You're shaking."

"I'm fine."

"You're not fine. You're hypothermic. Body heat is the only thing we've got. Come *here*."

Another *KRRACK* of lightning. In the flash he saw her face: the stubbornness, the calculation, the rapid-fire cost-benefit analysis happening behind those green eyes. Then the dark again.

She moved closer. Not all at once. In increments, like a cat approaching something it wasn't sure about. Her back pressed against his chest. Her shoulder blades against his pectorals. The curve of her spine against his stomach. He put his arm over her—there was nowhere else to put it, the tent was too narrow—and his hand settled against her stomach, fingers spread over the flat plane of her abdomen, and she was *cold*. Cold as river water.

"Christ, Mary."

"Don't." Her voice was tight. "Don't make it a thing."

"I'm not making it a thing."

"You're spooning me in your underwear. It's a thing."

"It's survival."

"It's a thing and we both know it, so just—don't talk. Don't talk and don't move your hand and don't—" She stopped. Her breath hitched. His hand was on her stomach and she was breathing against his palm and every inhale pressed her ribs against his fingers. "Don't make it weird."

"Wouldn't dream of it."

Silence. The rain. The wind. Her breathing, which was slowing, evening out as his body heat bled into her back and her shivering downgraded from violent to intermittent. His chin was above her head. He could smell her hair. Wet, but underneath the rain, her actual scent: something smoky and sharp, like cedar shavings and steel.

They lay there. Minutes passed. The storm didn't let up. The canvas sagged under the weight of the water, pressing down until it almost touched their faces, and outside, the world was noise and violence and dark.

"She's pretty," Mary said.

"What?"

"The noble. Jessamine." She said the name the way you'd say *toothache*. "I saw her. At the ball. I was outside, watching the entrance in case you needed a distraction. She came down the steps with her military escort and her diamond earrings and her tits pushed up to her chin in that green dress." A pause. "She's pretty."

"Mary—"

"I'm not saying anything. I'm stating a fact. She's pretty. Good for her. Born into a family with enough money to make anyone pretty: the right food, the right tailors, the right soap. Must be nice."

"You're not ugly."

"Oh *thank* you, Jonah, what a magnificent compliment, I'll treasure it forever: *you're not ugly*, every girl's dream—"

"I didn't mean—"

"You didn't mean anything. You never mean anything. That's the problem." She shifted against him, and the movement pressed her ass against his groin, and the contact—warm skin through wet cotton—sent a pulse of heat through him that had nothing to do with survival and everything to do with the fact that Mary Grieve was lying half-naked against him in the dark and her body fit against his like it had been designed for the purpose.

She felt it. Of course she felt it. He was hard—not fully, but enough—and pressed against her like this, there was no hiding it, no adjusting, no casual repositioning that would fool anyone.

She went still.

"Jonah."

"I can't help it. You're—we're—it's physiological."

"*Physiological.*" She laughed. Short, sharp, not quite amused. "That's what you're going with."

"What do you want me to say?"

"I want you to say something *honest* for once in your goddamn life." She turned in his arms. Rolled over, facing him now, and in the dark he could feel the geometry of her—the smallness, the sharpness, the angry heat of her breath on his collarbone. Her hand was on his chest, palm flat, fingers spread. Not pushing him away. Not pulling him closer. Holding position. "You've been here a week. One week. And you've already fucked a whore, robbed a ball, freed a cat-girl, and fallen for a noble who wouldn't spit on you if you were on fire. And I'm the one who set all of it up. Every single piece. I found you the room, the work, the fence, the invitation, the contact at the Burnt Rose. Me. Mary. And you look at me like I'm—like I'm *furniture*. Like I'm the table you put things on."

"That's not how I look at you."

"Then how? Tell me. Because from where I'm lying—and I'm lying *very* close to you right now, Jonah, in case you hadn't noticed—from where I'm lying, it seems like I'm good enough to plan your heists and find your contacts and save your ass, but when it comes to anything else, you'd rather pay two coppers at the Burnt Rose."

The rain hammered. Lightning flashed. In the strobe he saw her face—not angry. Not exactly. Something rawer than anger. Something that had been sitting behind the smirks and the ghost-smiles and the stolen apples for longer than a week.

"And I *know*, by the way," she said.

"Know what?"

"About your little fetish. The eastern thing. The—what did you call it—*irrumatio*." She said the word with a precision that made it clear she'd been thinking about it. "Lina talks. The girls at the Rose all talk. Word gets around when a fresh-off-the-boat ironworker walks in and asks for something most Veranesse men haven't even heard of." Her fingers curled slightly against his chest. Nails against skin. "You liked being in control. Of her mouth. Of the pace. Of all of it."

"Mary—"

"I'm not judging. I'm *telling* you I know." Her voice dropped. Lower. Quieter. The anger was still there but it had changed temperature—still hot, but a different kind of hot. "And I'm telling you that if you'd asked *me*—instead of walking into a whorehouse with coins I helped you earn—if you'd asked me, I would have—"

She stopped. Her breath caught. The sentence hung in the dark between them, unfinished, radioactive.

The rain thundered on the canvas. The wind screamed. His hand was on her lower back, fingers spread over the ridge of her spine, and her skin was warming under his touch, and her face was inches from his, and he could feel her breath on his mouth.

"You would have what," he said. Not a question. A dare.

"Don't do that."

"Do what."

"That voice. That low—*that*—don't do that to me, Jonah, because I swear to god if you start something right now and then pull back and give me some bullshit about timing or propriety or *it would complicate things*, I will stab you in this tent and leave your body for the wolves that definitely don't exist."

"I thought there weren't wolves."

"There will be when I'm done with you."

His hand slid from her lower back down to her hip. She inhaled—sharp, short, through her nose—*hhh*—and her body pressed forward against his,

closing the last inch of space between them. Her chest against his. Her hips against his. Her thigh sliding between his legs. Small, sharp, angular—every edge of her pressing into him—and he was fully hard now, no ambiguity, no *physiological* excuse, just want, plain and undeniable, pressed against her stomach through two layers of wet cotton.

"Mary," he said.

"What."

"Shut up."

He kissed her.

She made a sound against his mouth—not a moan, not yet, something more like a gasp of relief, like a breath she'd been holding for days finally released—*nnh*—and her hands grabbed his jaw, both sides, pulling him into her, kissing him back with the desperate ferocity of a woman who had been waiting for this exact moment and was furious that it had taken this long.

She tasted like rain and gin. Her tongue was quick and aggressive, the same way she was quick and aggressive about everything—no hesitation, no gentleness, just *hunger*. Her nails raked down his neck, his chest, leaving lines he'd feel in the morning. Her hips ground forward, rolling against his cock through the wet fabric, and the friction was maddening—not enough, too much, the worst kind of tease.

He grabbed her ass—small, tight, barely a handful—and pulled her harder against him, and she gasped into his mouth—*"Ah—"*—and bit his lower lip, hard enough to sting, hard enough to draw blood.

"*Fuck*," he breathed.

"Yeah," she panted. "That's the general idea."

His hand slid down her stomach, past the waistband of her smallclothes—soaked, clinging to her—and between her thighs. She was wet. Not from the rain. Slick and hot against his fingers, and when he touched her she jerked against him like she'd been shocked—*"Nnh—fuck—"*—her forehead dropping against his collarbone, her breath coming in fast, shuddering bursts against his skin.

"How long?" he asked, his fingers moving, slow, deliberate. "How long have you wanted this?"

"Since you—*hhh*—since you grabbed my wrist on the docks. The first—*mmh*—the first minute I met you. Your stupid—*ah*—stupid fucking hands—"

He pushed a finger inside her and she bit his shoulder—actually *bit* him, teeth sinking into the muscle, muffled cry vibrating against his skin —*"MMHH"*—and her hips bucked forward, riding his hand with the same desperate urgency she brought to everything.

She was tight. Small all the way through. And loud—louder than he expected—sounds leaking out of her that she couldn't control, couldn't muffle even with her face pressed into his neck—*nnh, nnh, nnh*—sharp, staccato, building.

Lightning cracked outside. *KRRACK.* The tent lit up white and he saw her—eyes squeezed shut, mouth open against his skin, her whole body coiled and shaking.

"Jonah—I want—" She pulled back, breathing hard, and her hand shoved down between them, grabbing him through the cotton. "*This*. I want this. Now."

He yanked her smallclothes down. She kicked them off—one ankle, then the other—and climbed onto him, straddling his hips in the cramped dark of the tent, the canvas brushing her back, and she reached down and guided him in herself, no ceremony, no pause, just a single downward push and—

"Ohhhh fuck—"

That was both of them. Simultaneously. In stereo.

She was tight—almost painfully so, her body clenching around him in waves of involuntary pressure—and the heat of her after the cold of the rain was like plunging his cock into a furnace. She grabbed his shoulders and started moving—short, grinding rolls of her hips, nothing like the long, theatrical strokes Lina had used—this was urgent, economical, *angry*, like she was trying to extract something from him through sheer friction.

"You're—*hhh*—you're an asshole," she panted, riding him, her nails digging into his shoulders. "You know that? A—*nnh*—complete fucking—*ah* —asshole—"

"I know—"

"You walked into my city—*mmh*—with eleven coppers and your—*hhh*—stupid jaw and your stupid grey eyes and you—*ah, ah*—you didn't even *see* me—"

"I see you now."

"*Don't*—" Her voice cracked. Something broke open in it, something she'd been holding shut with both hands. "Don't say that to me while you're—*nnh*

—while you're inside me—you don't get to—*ah fuck, right there*—you don't get to say sweet shit to me, Jonah, I'll—I'll fucking *kill* you—"

He grabbed her hips and thrust up into her and she cried out—loud, raw, the sound swallowed by the storm—and her head dropped back and her spine arched and the canvas pressed against her shoulders and outside the thunder rolled and the rain hammered and neither of them heard any of it.

It was fast. It was messy. It was elbows and knees and the tent pole nearly collapsing twice and her biting his chest and him biting her neck and both of them making sounds that would have been embarrassing in any context except this one—two cold, soaked, angry, desperate people fucking in a canvas coffin in the middle of a storm because they'd waited too long and couldn't wait anymore.

She came first—clenching hard around him, her whole body locking up, a strangled sound tearing out of her—*"NNH—FUCK—JONAH—"*—his name, his actual name, ripped out of her like a confession she'd been holding back under torture. He followed ten seconds later, grabbing her hips hard enough to bruise, burying himself as deep as he could, spilling into her with a groan that started in his chest and ended somewhere outside his body.

Collapse.

She fell forward onto his chest. He wrapped both arms around her. They lay there, breathing, the storm raging above them, the canvas shuddering, the world reduced to the sound of rain and their own heartbeats gradually decelerating from crisis to something approaching normal.

Her cheek was on his chest. Her fingers were tracing the burn scar on his ribs. Small circles. Absent-minded. The kind of touch that happens after the urgency drains away and what's left is just—contact. Skin. Warmth.

"If you tell anyone about this," she said quietly, "I'll deny it."

"Who would I tell?"

"Your cat-girl. Your noble. Your *harem*."

"I don't have a harem."

"Jonah. You have three women in your orbit and you've been in this city a week. You have a harem. You just haven't admitted it yet."

She tilted her chin up. He looked down. In the dark, her green eyes caught the faintest ambient light filtering through the canvas—just enough to see the expression on her face, which was complicated. Angry and tender and scared and satisfied and already building the walls back up, brick by brick, because

Mary Grieve didn't leave her walls down for anyone, not even the man she'd just fucked in a rainstorm.

"Don't break my heart," she said. "I'll survive it, because I survive everything, but I'd rather not."

"Mary—"

"Don't promise anything. I don't trust promises. Just—don't go out of your way to break it. That's all I'm asking."

He kissed her forehead. She let him. For about three seconds. Then she flicked his ear—*thwip*—and rolled off him and curled up against his side with her back to him, pulling the one blanket—which had somehow stayed dry in the chaos—over both of them.

"We're going again in twenty minutes," she said into the dark. "And this time you're going to do that eastern thing."

"What eastern thing."

"Don't play dumb. The mouth thing. The *irrumatio*. Lina says you nearly put her through the wall." A beat. "I want to see what the fuss is about."

"Mary—"

"Twenty minutes. Set a mental clock."

The storm howled. The rain hammered. The tent held, barely.

Jonah stared at the canvas ceiling and felt Mary's breathing slow against his ribs and the warmth build between them in the narrow space and he thought about Jessamine's navy eyes and Sable's amber ones and Mary's green ones—three colors, three women, three entirely different kinds of trouble—and he was in over his head and sinking fast and the strangest part, the part he couldn't explain even to himself, was that he didn't want to come up for air.

The storm raged on through the night, and the tent held, and the wolves—which definitely didn't exist—howled somewhere in the distant treeline like they were laughing at him.

She wasn't asleep. He knew because her breathing never settled into the slow, even rhythm of actual rest—it stayed shallow, quick, the breathing of a woman counting seconds in her head. Her back was warm against his chest. Her hair smelled like rain and cedar. His cock had never fully gone down—half-mast at best, the stubborn bastard—and pressed against the small of her back through the blanket like a fact neither of them was acknowledging.

At what he estimated was eighteen minutes, she spoke.

"Time."

"You were counting?"

"I'm always counting." She rolled over. Facing him. In the dark he could feel her breath on his chin, warm and quick. "Tell me what to do."

"Mary—"

"Don't *Mary* me. I said I wanted to try it and I meant it. I don't say things I don't mean. That's your department." Her hand found his chest, pressed flat. Her fingers were warm now. "Tell me what to do. Like you told Lina."

"I didn't tell Lina much. She knew what she was doing."

"Well I don't. So teach me."

There was something in her voice—underneath the bravado, underneath the sharp edges and the profanity—something small and fierce and honest. Mary Grieve didn't ask for help. Mary Grieve didn't admit she didn't know things. The fact that she was doing both, here, in the dark, naked against him in a canvas tent with a storm trying to tear the world apart outside—that meant something. He wasn't stupid enough to waste it.

"Okay," he said. "Okay. First thing—it's not like regular. You don't move. I do. That's the whole point. You kneel, you open, and you let me set the pace."

"I know the concept. I'm not an idiot."

"I know you're not. But knowing the concept and doing it are different. The reflex is going to hit you—the gag, the tightness in your throat. Your body's going to tell you to pull back. That's normal. You breathe through your nose, keep your jaw slack, and if you need me to stop, you tap my thigh. Twice. That's the signal."

"Same as Lina's."

"It works."

"Fine." She pushed herself up—a rustle of canvas, the blanket falling away—and he felt her shifting position in the dark, her knees finding the ground on either side of his legs. The tent was so cramped she had to hunch forward, the canvas pressing against her back. "Sit up."

He sat up. His back against the bundled packs they'd shoved to the rear of the tent. His legs out in front of him, slightly bent. She was between them, kneeling, her hands on his thighs. He could feel the heat of her palms through the thin layer of skin and muscle. His cock was fully hard now—had been since she'd said *time*—standing stiff against his stomach in the dark.

"You're already—" She stopped. Her fingers brushed him. Tentative. Not the rough, confident grab from earlier. Something more careful. Exploratory. "Christ, Jonah. You've been like this the whole twenty minutes?"

"Closer to the whole hour."

"That seems medically concerning."

"Are you going to make jokes or are you going to—"

"Both. I'm going to do both." Her hand wrapped around him properly. Firm grip, slim fingers, not quite reaching all the way around. She stroked once, slow, base to tip, and his breath hissed through his teeth—*sssshh*. "Okay. I'm—yeah. Okay."

He felt her shift lower. Her breath on him first—warm, unsteady, hitting the sensitive underside in gusts that made his stomach tighten. Then her lips. A kiss, almost—light, tentative, pressed to the head of his cock with the caution of someone handling something they weren't sure wouldn't bite them.

"Open," he said. Gently. As gently as he could manage with his pulse hammering in his ears. "Wider. Jaw slack. Tongue flat."

She opened. He felt it—the wet heat of her mouth closing around him, lips stretched, tongue pressing flat against the underside. She took maybe two inches. Held there. Breathing hard through her nose—*hhh, hhh, hhh*—fast, nervous. Not the slow, practiced breathing Lina had used. The breathing of a woman doing something for the first time and trying very hard not to fuck it up.

He slid his hands into her hair. Wet, tangled, rougher than Lina's—no silk here, no rosewater, just Mary, rain-soaked and real. He gathered it at the back of her head, both hands, holding loosely.

"I'm going to move," he said. "Slow. You tap if you need me to stop."

She made a sound—*mmh*—which he took as assent.

He pushed forward. Half an inch. An inch. Slow, careful, watching the feel of her mouth the way a locksmith watches tumblers—reading the tension, the resistance, the give. She was tighter than Lina. Her jaw wasn't as relaxed, the muscles fighting the stretch, and her tongue was stiff instead of pliant, pressing up against the underside of his shaft with an involuntary pressure that was—actually—*fuck*—incredibly intense in a different way. Rougher. Less technique, more friction.

"That's good," he said. "You're doing good. Just—relax the jaw a little more. Let it—yeah. Like that."

She adjusted. Marginally. Her jaw dropped another centimeter and the pressure eased and he pushed a little deeper and hit the back of her mouth and—

"GHHK—"

She gagged. Hard. Her whole body convulsed, throat clamping shut, and she jerked backward off him, coughing, spit trailing from her lips in a string that caught the faintest light.

"*Kkhh—hhkk—*" Coughing. Wiping her mouth. He could hear the embarrassment in the quality of the silence that followed—the specific, loaded silence of Mary Grieve failing at something and hating herself for it.

"That's normal," he said quickly. "First time, that's completely—"

"I *know* it's normal, shut up." Her voice was hoarse. Tight. "Again. I'm going again."

"Mary, you don't have to—"

"I said *again*."

She came back. Mouth open. He slid in. Slower this time. She took him to the same depth—two inches, maybe two and a half—and held. Her breathing was erratic through her nose, nostrils flaring with each exhale, and he could feel the tension in her jaw, the effort it was taking her to keep it slack. Her hands gripped his thighs, fingernails pressing crescents into the muscle.

He moved. Gentle strokes. Short. Barely withdrawing before pushing back to the same depth. Not going deeper. Letting her adjust to the motion, the rhythm, the feeling of his cock sliding over her tongue while her head stayed still.

"*Mmh—mmh—mmh—*"

Small sounds. Muffled. Half-distress, half-determination. The sounds of a woman who would rather choke than quit.

"Good," he breathed. "That's good. You're—*nngh*—you feel good, Mary."

And she did. Different from Lina—less polished, less controlled, but the rawness of it, the *effort*—there was something about knowing this was new for her, that she was doing it because she'd heard about it and wanted to be the one to give it to him, that made his cock throb in her mouth and his fingers tighten in her hair.

He sped up. Just slightly. The strokes lengthened—pulling back further, pushing in a little deeper—and he felt her throat tighten each time he touched the back of her mouth, a reflexive clench she couldn't control, and he pushed through it once—just barely, just the head of his cock pressing past the resistance into the first ring of her throat—

"GHHK—GHHK—"

She pulled off again. Hard. Coughing, gasping, and this time the silence afterward was different. Not just embarrassment. Something closer to frustration. The particular fury of someone confronting the gap between what they want to be and what they are.

"Fuck," she whispered. Hoarse. Wet. "*Fuck.*"

"Hey—"

"Don't. Don't *hey* me." She was breathing hard. He could hear the tremor in it—not tears, Mary didn't cry, but something adjacent. The vibration of a wire pulled too tight. "I can't—my throat—it just—"

"Mary. Listen to me."

"I'm not *good* at it, okay? Is that what you want to hear? Lina's a professional and I'm a fucking pickpocket who's sucked exactly three cocks in her life and none of them went past my *teeth*, so—"

"Mary. *Listen.*"

She went quiet. Breathing. The rain hammered.

"You were good," he said. "You were. The way you felt—the tightness, the way your tongue—you were good. This takes practice. Lina's done it a thousand times. This was your first. Nobody's good the first time."

"You don't have to coddle me."

"I'm not coddling you. I'm telling you the truth. And we're going to stop."

Silence. A different kind. Wounded.

"Because I'm bad at it."

"Because it's late and you're tired and your throat's sore and we're in a tent in a fucking hurricane and this isn't how I want this to go. Not with you." He reached out in the dark, found her face. His thumb traced her cheekbone. Wet. Not tears—rain, residual rain—but she flinched at the tenderness like it burned. "Not rushed. Not because you're trying to compete with a whore from the Burnt Rose."

"I'm not *competing*—"

"Yeah you are. And you don't need to. She's a transaction. You're—" He stopped. Reconsidered the sentence. Chose a different one. "You're Mary."

"What the fuck does that mean?"

"It means get over here and go to sleep."

She didn't move for a long moment. He could feel her kneeling there in the dark, that fierce little engine of pride and hunger and stubbornness running hot, trying to decide whether to fight or fold. Mary Grieve didn't fold. But sometimes—rarely, and only when no one could see—she bent.

She lay down beside him. Pulled the blanket up. Her back to his chest again, the same position as before, except now his cock was pressed against her ass—fully, stubbornly, unrelentingly hard—and they both knew it and neither of them said anything about it.

Her hand found his where it rested on her stomach. She interlaced their fingers. Squeezed once. Hard.

"Next time," she said quietly. "When we're somewhere with a real bed and I've had practice. I'll do it right."

"You don't have to—"

"I *want* to do it right. I want to be the one who—" She stopped. Swallowed. Her throat clicked—still raw, still sore. "I want to be the one you think about. Not Lina. Not—not *Jessamine*. Me. I want you to close your eyes and see *my* mouth."

His cock pulsed against her. She felt it. Made a sound that was almost a laugh.

"Clearly the spirit is willing," she muttered.

"Mary."

"Go to sleep, Jonah."

"I can't exactly sleep like this."

"Suffer." She pressed back against him—deliberately, cruelly, grinding her ass into his erection for one excruciating second—then settled. "Consider it motivation to come back to me."

He lay there. Hard. Aching. His hand on her stomach, her fingers laced through his, her breathing gradually slowing against his palm. The storm was easing—the thunder rolling further away, the rain thinning from a roar to a steady drum on the canvas. The wind dropped. The trees stopped groaning.

She fell asleep before he did. He knew because her grip loosened and her breathing deepened and her body went heavy and slack against him, that

particular weight of genuine unconsciousness that can't be faked.

He stared at the canvas above his face and willed his body to cooperate and his body told him to go fuck himself, which—given the circumstances—felt like the universe's idea of a joke.

The storm moved east. The rain softened. Somewhere, distantly, a bird made a tentative sound—*chirp?*—testing whether the world was safe again.

Jonah closed his eyes and did not sleep for a very long time.

Chapter Seven

Substitution



He didn't make it to the warehouse.

Goss would dock him a day's pay. Four coppers gone. He didn't care. The walk back from the forest had been twelve miles of hell: Mary half a step ahead, not talking, not looking at him, both of them in damp clothes that clung and chafed, the morning sun breaking through the post-storm clouds with the cheerful indifference of a world that hadn't spent the night in a canvas coffin with an erection that could hammer nails.

She'd spoken exactly once. Somewhere around the third mile, where the forest thinned into scrub and the first chimney smoke of the outer Lowers showed on the horizon, she'd stopped walking. Not turned around. Just stopped, her back to him, her wet shirt plastered to her shoulder blades.

"The guards," she'd said. "At the station. Marks is going to want to know who talked."

"So tell him we don't know."

"He won't care what we know. He'll care who he can blame." A pause. Her fingers curled at her sides. "When he asks—and he will—let me do the talking. Whatever I say. Don't contradict me."

"Mary. What do you owe him?"

She'd stood there a long moment. Long enough that he thought she was going to answer. Her shoulders rose, a breath drawn to say something true, and held there.

Then they came down.

"Don't," she'd said, and started walking again, and that was the end of it.

They'd parted at Bent Street without a word. She went left. He went right. She didn't look back. He didn't call after her.

He went to his room. Sat on the mattress. Sable was curled in the corner by the door, her spot, the one she'd claimed and defended with a hiss when he'd tried to put a pillow there, sleeping in a tight ball with her tail over her nose, ears flat, dead to the world. She'd eaten everything in the room while he was gone. Three apples, half a loaf, and a wedge of cheese he'd been saving. He was too wrecked to be annoyed.

He sat there for twenty minutes. His cock was still hard. Not fully—it had dropped to that miserable half-state during the walk, the kind that sits heavy between your legs like an unfinished argument—but every time he closed his eyes he was back in the tent. Mary's mouth. The wet heat. Her tongue, stiff and unpracticed, pressing against the underside of his shaft. The gagging—*GHHK*—and the way she'd pulled off, humiliated, furious, her voice scraped raw: *I want to be the one you think about.*

And deeper than that, underneath the memory of Mary, the thing that shamed him—the image his brain kept reaching for when his cock pulsed: not Mary's face but Jessamine's. Navy eyes looking up at him. That full, dark-red mouth opening. That aristocratic jaw going slack. The fantasy was involuntary and persistent and he hated himself for it and it didn't stop.

He needed to finish what had started. Not with Mary—that was a wound he couldn't reopen without bleeding out. Not with his own hand—he'd tried on the walk, stepped behind a tree while Mary was ahead, managed three strokes before the angle and the discomfort and the sheer fucking *indignity* of jerking off in a forest made him stop.

He needed Lina.

He needed something specific from Lina.

He got up. Walked to the Burnt Rose. It was mid-morning. The place was mostly empty, the squeeze-box mercifully silent, the parlor smelling like spilled gin and last night's tobacco. Della was behind the bar, polishing a glass with a rag that was dirtier than the glass.

"Lina," Jonah said. "Is she working?"

Della looked at him. That weathered, unsurprisable face. "It's ten in the morning."

"Is she working."

"Two coppers."

He put them on the bar. Five left. He was hemorrhaging money.

"She's upstairs. Room four. Knock first, she bites when she's startled." Della paused. "That's a joke. Mostly."

Lina opened the door in a cotton shift, her black hair braided for sleep, eyes puffy. She looked at him, registered something—whatever was on his face, and it must have been considerable—and stepped aside without a word.

The room was the same. Iron bed, washbasin, candle, shuttered window. Daylight leaked through the slats in thin gold lines.

"You look like hell," she said, sitting on the edge of the bed. "When's the last time you slept?"

"I need something."

"Obviously. You're here at ten in the morning looking like a man who's been fucked sideways by a bad night. What do you need?"

He told her.

Lina listened. Her face didn't change—not shock, not judgment, just the steady professional attention of a woman who had been asked for stranger things and would be asked for stranger things again. When he finished, she was quiet for a moment. Fingers laced in her lap. Those heavy-lidded brown eyes reading him.

"You want me to dress like her," she said.

"The shirt. The hair. That's it."

"Auburn wig. Man's linen shirt, oversized. Nothing else underneath."

"Yes."

"And then the eastern thing. The irrumatio. But rougher than last time."

"Yes."

"How rough?"

"Rough."

She studied him. A long, careful look—the look of a craftsman assessing whether a particular job fell within her capabilities and tolerances. Then she nodded.

"I've got a wig. Calleni silk, auburn, cut short. Not exact, but close enough in this light." She stood, walked to a trunk in the corner, rummaged. Came up

with a wig—dark auburn, choppy, the kind of piece that working girls kept for clients with specific tastes. She held it up. The color was close. Not Mary's exact shade—nothing would be—but in the gold-slatted light leaking through the shutters, it would do. "Shirt, I can get from downstairs. One of the barmen has a linen that's about the right size. Give me five minutes."

She left. Came back. White linen shirt—huge, long-sleeved, the kind that would hang off a woman Mary's size like a tent. She set it on the bed beside the wig and looked at him.

"Ground rules," she said. "Same as before—I tap twice, you stop. But if you're going deeper than last time, I need you to hold at the base for no longer than five seconds at a time. I can take it, but my lungs need to work. And if I push your hips back, you pull out completely and let me breathe. Deal?"

"Deal."

"Good. Turn around."

He turned. Heard the shift come off—a whisper of cotton—and the shirt go on. Buttons, a few of them, the rest left open. Then the wig—a rustle, an adjustment. She cleared her throat.

"Okay."

He turned back.

His stomach dropped.

She wasn't Mary. She was taller, fuller, her body all curves where Mary was angles and edges. But the *impression*—the oversized white shirt falling off one shoulder, the auburn hair choppy and rough around her jaw, bare legs beneath the untucked hem—the impression was close enough that his brain stuttered, caught between what it saw and what it wanted to see, and his cock went from half-mast to iron in about two seconds flat.

"That bad, huh?" Lina said, watching his reaction. She adjusted the wig, tucking a strand behind her ear, and the gesture—casual, habitual—was so close to something Mary would do that his chest tightened.

"Sit down," he said. His voice came out lower than he intended. Rougher. Something had shifted in him—the restraint he'd held last time, the patience, the careful pacing—that was gone. Burned off by twelve miles of blue-balled agony and a night of being so close to what he wanted that he could taste it and not being able to swallow.

Lina sat on the edge of the bed. Looked up at him. The auburn wig framed her face in a way that was wrong and right at the same time—wrong because

her features were softer than Mary's, her jaw rounder, her mouth fuller—but right because in the striped daylight, with the shirt sliding off her shoulder and her legs bare and her eyes looking up at him with steady, knowing patience, his brain could do the rest.

"On the floor," he said. "Knees."

She slid off the bed. *Thunk.* Knees on the bare wood, hands on her thighs. Looking up. Waiting.

He stepped forward. Pulled his trousers open. His cock sprang free—thick, dark, leaking at the tip, the head flushed an angry purple from hours of denied release. He was so hard it hurt, a deep ache that radiated from his balls through his groin and up into his stomach like a coiled fist.

He slid both hands into the wig. The texture was different—silk instead of real hair, smoother, cooler—but he gripped it the same way, gathered at the back, wrapped once around his fist.

"Open," he said.

She opened. Wide, jaw dropped, tongue flat, those brown eyes steady and waiting.

He pushed in. Not slow. Not careful. Not the tentative, measured strokes he'd used last time. He pushed in deep—past her tongue, past the back of her mouth, into her throat—in one stroke, and the sound she made—*GLHK*—was thick and wet and loud in the small room.

"*Fuck*—" The word tore out of him. The feeling—hot, tight, the muscles of her throat clenching reflexively around the head of his cock before deliberately relaxing, opening, *accepting*—was so intense after the night he'd had that his vision pulsed and his knees shook.

He pulled back. Pushed in again. Harder. Deeper. Found a rhythm immediately—not the slow, exploratory pace of their first session but something faster, meaner, each stroke driving to the hilt and holding for one—two—three seconds before withdrawing and slamming back. The sounds were obscene—wet, choking, guttural—*GLK, GLK, GLK*—filling the room, bouncing off the plaster walls, loud enough that anyone in the hallway would know exactly what was happening.

Lina took it. Her hands stayed on her thighs. Her eyes watered—tears streaming down her cheeks, mixing with the spit that was already running down her chin, dripping onto the white shirt—and her throat worked around

him each time he pushed deep, that swallowing ripple that had nearly killed him last time.

But something was different. He could feel it in himself—a rawness, a fury, something animal and clenched and *mean* that had been building since the tent. Every stroke was a continuation of what had started with Mary—the unfinished sentence, the half-spoken confession, the hands in the wrong hair and the mouth that had tried and couldn't and the *frustration* of all of it—and he was taking it out on Lina's throat with a ferocity that he knew, dimly, in the small rational part of his brain that was still functioning, was beyond what he'd done before.

He grabbed the wig tighter. Pulled her head forward. Thrust his hips forward at the same time, meeting in the middle, and her nose pressed flat against his pelvis and he felt her throat spasm—*GLHK, GLHK*—struggling, adjusting, the muscles fluttering around his shaft, and she held—three seconds, four, five—before he pulled back and she gasped through her nose—*HHHHH*—a desperate, snorting intake of air, spit bridging from her lips to his cock in thick strings.

"*Again,*" he growled, and pushed back in before she'd fully recovered.

Her hands came off her thighs. Grabbed his hips. Not tapping—not the signal—*gripping*. Fingernails digging into the muscles above his hipbones, holding on, anchoring herself while he fucked her throat with short, vicious strokes that made the iron bed frame rattle against the wall—*clank, clank, clank*.

"*Nnh—nnh—nnh—*" Sounds vibrating around his cock, involuntary, guttural, each one sending a shockwave through his shaft into his spine. Her eyes were squeezed shut now, tears and spit and snot running together, the auburn wig askew, the white shirt soaked through at the collar.

He was close. The orgasm was building at the base of his cock like pressure behind a dam—huge, structural, the kind that would break something when it let go. But he didn't want to finish like this. Not in her mouth. Not this time. The animal thing in him—the thing that had been caged since the tent, since Mary's bare skin against his, since the storm—wanted more. Wanted *everything*.

He pulled out. Lina gasped—*"HAAAHH"*—chest heaving, spit pouring down her chin, mascara streaked, the wig half-off. She looked wrecked. Ruined. And she was smiling.

"There he is," she rasped. Raw-voiced. Barely a whisper. "Was wondering when you'd stop being polite."

"Bend over."

She didn't hesitate. She stood—legs shaking, Christ, her legs were actually shaking—and turned to the small table by the window. It was narrow, wooden, the kind that held a washbasin and nothing else. She swept the basin to the floor—*CRASH*—and bent forward over the table, her forearms flat on the surface, the white shirt riding up over her hips, and she looked back over her shoulder at him through the auburn wig and her ruined makeup and said:

"Don't hold back."

He didn't.

He was behind her in two steps, one hand on her hip, one hand on the back of her neck—pressing her down, flat against the table—and he pushed into her in one brutal stroke that shoved the table six inches across the floor with a screech—*SKREEEEE*—wood on wood, and she cried out—*"AH FUCK"*—loud, genuine, not performance, and he started moving.

Not lovemaking. Not the rolling, grinding rhythm Mary had used in the tent. This was something else—raw, percussive, each thrust slamming her hips against the table edge, her feet lifting off the floor with every impact. The table legs barked against the boards—*THUNK THUNK THUNK THUNK*—a relentless staccato that competed with the slap of skin on skin and the sounds coming out of both of them—his grunting, low and animal, and hers, sharp staccato cries that shattered into fragments—*"AH—AH—AH—FUCK—AH—"*

He grabbed the wig. Pulled her head back. Her spine arched, throat exposed, and he leaned over her, his chest against her back, his mouth against her ear.

"You know who I'm thinking about," he said. Not a question.

"*Mmhm—*" Gasped. Grinning. Even now, bent over a table getting hammered into next week, Lina was grinning. "*She's—hhh—lucky—*"

"She doesn't know."

"*She—AH—she will—*"

He straightened up. Both hands on her hips now. Pulling her back into every thrust, using her body's weight as counterforce, and the table was screaming across the floor—six inches, a foot, bumping against the wall, and

the wall shook and somewhere in the next room someone banged—*THUMP THUMP*—either in complaint or solidarity.

He was close. The pressure was nuclear—hours of it, the whole night, Mary's mouth and the storm and the tent and the walk and every denied, deferred, frustrated minute of wanting something he couldn't have compressing into a single white-hot point at the base of his cock that was seconds from detonation.

"*Lina—I'm—*"

"*Do it—*" Her voice was barely there. Shredded. "*Give me all of it—*"

He slammed into her one final time—the table hit the wall with a *BANG*—and came so hard his vision went black at the edges and his hands locked on her hips like vises and the sound that came out of him was not a groan or a roar but something between them, something primitive and agonized and *relieved*, like a man coming up from underwater after being held down too long.

"*AAHHH—FUCK—FUCK—*"

Pulse after pulse. He could feel each one, distinct, volcanic, his cock buried to the hilt, her body clenching around him in rhythmic waves. The table creaked. Lina's fingers clawed the wood surface, leaving scratch marks. The wig had come half off, hanging sideways, the auburn silk tangled with her real black hair underneath.

Stillness.

The room smelled like sex and sweat and the stale morning light through the shutters. His heart was trying to escape through his chest. His legs were water. His hands were trembling where they gripped her hips.

Lina lay across the table, breathing. Long, ragged inhales. Slow, shuddering exhales. Her back rose and fell under the soaked white shirt. After a moment she turned her head sideways on the wood and looked at him with one eye.

"That," she said, her voice a destroyed whisper, "was not about me."

"No."

"The shirt. The wig. The mouth. You were somewhere else the entire time."

"Yes."

She didn't look offended. She looked *satisfied*. The satisfaction of a professional who has been given a difficult brief and executed it flawlessly.

"It's the small one, isn't it," she said. "The one Mary told me about. Green eyes. Quick mouth. Pickpocket."

He pulled out. Slow. Stepped back. His legs almost went. He caught the bed frame. Sat down heavily.

"I don't want to talk about it."

"You never do." Lina peeled herself off the table with the careful movements of someone cataloguing new aches. She pulled the wig off, shook her real hair free, wiped her face with the hem of the shirt. She looked at him —red-eyed, spit-smeared, streaked with tears, thoroughly used—and she looked *amused*.

"You're in trouble, dock boy," she said.

"I know."

"Not this kind of trouble." She gestured at the room—the smashed washbasin, the displaced table, the scratch marks on the wood. "This kind I can handle. This kind pays my rent. I mean the other kind. The kind where you're fucking one woman while thinking about another and paying a third to pretend to be her." She filled a cup with water from the pitcher, drank, filled it again, and handed it to him. "That kind of trouble doesn't end at a whorehouse, Jonah."

He drank. The water was warm and tasted like tin and it was the best thing he'd ever tasted.

"Two coppers," Lina said. "Plus a tip for the table. And the basin. And my voice, which will be gone for the rest of the day." She sat on the bed next to him, leaned her shoulder against his. The intimate casualness of a woman who had just been used as a surrogate and bore no grudge about it. "Go home. Sleep. And when you wake up, go talk to her. The real one. Before this gets any more complicated."

Jonah finished the water. Set the cup on the floor. The daylight through the shutters was warmer now—mid-morning shifting toward noon. He could hear the Lowers waking up outside—cart wheels on cobblestone, vendors calling, the distant hiss and chuff of the rail line.

He left a silver on the nightstand. Overpayment. Lina had earned it.

He had his hand on the latch when she spoke again.

"Dock boy."

He looked back. She was sitting on the bed with the wig in her lap, combing the silk straight with her fingers, not looking at him.

"There's a captain who comes Tuesdays," she said. "Blond. Oils his hair. Buttons his collar to the throat even when he's got his trousers off. Military type. Pays well and tips badly."

Thorne. The dog at the balcony door.

"Last night he wasn't interested in what I do. He was asking questions instead. Every girl in the house, one at a time." Her fingers kept moving through the wig. Slow. Steady. "Someone wearing a lord's name walked out of the Ashburn coatroom with half the Crescent's pocket watches. The real Lord Vell's in the eastern provinces—they've sent a wire to confirm it. Your captain wants the man who wore his face. He's paying silver for a name."

The room got very quiet.

"Did you give him one?"

Lina looked up then. Those heavy-lidded brown eyes, calm and unreadable and entirely awake.

"Not yet," she said. "I don't sell things the first time someone asks. Price goes up if you wait." She went back to the wig. "Close the door on your way out. And dock boy—wash. You smell like rain and a woman who isn't me. He's not the only one in this city with a nose."

He walked back to Bent Street in the noon sun, the midnight blue suit wrinkled and rank, his body finally—*finally*—quiet, the animal in his chest fed and sleeping. Sable was awake when he got back, sitting cross-legged by the door, chewing on something she'd scavenged: bread, it looked like. Her amber eyes tracking him as he collapsed onto the mattress.

"You smell like a brothel," she said flatly. Her ears rotated backward. Disapproval, apparently, had a specific ear position.

"Yep."

"And a forest. And sweat. And at least two different women."

"Felinara nose. Great."

"It's not a superpower. You just reek." She took another bite of bread. Chewed. Those amber eyes, unblinking. "The small angry one. Mary. She was here this morning, while you were gone. Sat on the steps for twenty minutes. Didn't knock. Left."

Something twisted in his chest. A knot pulling tighter.

"What did she look like?"

"Like a woman deciding whether to burn something down." Sable's tail flicked. Once. "Go to sleep, human. You're a disaster."

He rolled over. Closed his eyes. Smelled cedar and rain and rosewater and sex, all layered together, and underneath it all, the thing Lina had folded into his pocket like a blade: *Not yet.*

A captain hunting a borrowed name. A slaver's token on a noble's gate. A job sold before it started.

He slept. Dreamless. Heavy. The deep, black, merciless sleep of a man who had emptied everything he had into the wrong woman and knew it and couldn't take it back and wasn't entirely sure he wanted to.

Outside, the city ground on. The rail trestles hummed. The harbor stank. And somewhere in the Lowers, Mary Grieve sat on the steps of a chandler's shop with her knees pulled up and her green glass-bottle eyes fixed on nothing, deciding exactly how much of her heart she was willing to risk on a man who smelled like someone else.

Chapter Eight

Business



He found her at the Kettle, a dockside gin house three streets south of Bent Street that smelled like boiled cabbage and bad decisions. The sign above the door had been a copper kettle once but salt air and neglect had turned it into a green lump that looked more like a tumor than a utensil. Inside, the light was the color of old piss, filtered through windows so caked with grime they might as well have been painted shut.

Mary was in the back, at a table that had been positioned specifically so its occupant could see both exits and the bar. Smart. The kind of seating choice you made when your line of work involved people who might want to kill you.

She wasn't alone.

Marks took up most of the booth. Not figuratively—*literally*. The man was enormous. Six-five, three hundred and change, with shoulders that could have served as a shelf for a moderately sized child. His head was shaved to stubble, revealing a scalp that was a topographical map of old scars: a knife wound above the left ear, a burn scar along the back of his skull, and something that looked like a bite mark on his right temple, which Jonah chose not to think about. His face was surprisingly delicate for a man his size: small dark eyes set deep beneath a prominent brow, a nose that had been broken and reset at least four times, and a mouth that was almost feminine in its fullness, currently pursed around the stub of a cigarillo that smoldered between fingers thick as sausages.

He wore a coat—black, leather, long enough to brush his calves—over a waistcoat of dark burgundy that strained across his barrel chest. Gold chain. Gold rings, four of them, two per hand, heavy enough to double as knuckledusters. A walking stick leaned against the booth beside him: ebony, silver-capped, with a weighted head that was absolutely, definitely a weapon.

This was Marks. Markus Delaine, technically, but nobody called him that because nobody who called him that tended to keep their teeth. The Lowers called him Marks the Big, which was unimaginative but accurate. He ran the south docks: smuggling, fencing, protection, and a loan operation that charged interest rates best described as *theological*. Not the biggest kingpin in Veranesse. Not the most dangerous. But the most *accessible*, the man you went to when you needed work that paid real coin and didn't mind that the work involved breaking several Communion laws simultaneously.

Mary had introduced Jonah to Marks on day four. Marks had looked at Jonah the way a man looks at a new hammer, evaluating weight, grip, and how much damage it could do to a specific surface. He'd apparently liked what he saw, because the cargo intercept, the job that had ended in the storm and the tent and the whole catastrophe, had been a Marks job. First of several, if things went well.

Things had not gone well. And not only because of the job.

Mary didn't look up when Jonah approached the table. She was studying a hand-drawn map spread across the surface: charcoal on brown paper, detailed, showing what looked like the interior layout of a building. Rail station, maybe. Or a warehouse. Her dark auburn hair was tied back in the usual messy knot, the bent nail glinting dull in the lamplight. She wore the man's shirt. The corset. The cut-off trousers. Same as always. As if nothing had changed. As if there hadn't been a tent and a storm and her mouth on his cock and her voice saying *I want to be the one you think about.*

Marks looked up. The cigarillo glowed orange as he inhaled. *Fffhhhh.* Smoke curled from his nostrils.

"Wren." His voice was deep enough to register as seismic activity. A bass rumble that came from somewhere in his chest cavity and arrived at your ears having traveled through several geological layers. "Sit."

Jonah sat. The bench creaked under even his weight, which meant it was performing a daily miracle holding Marks.

"The silk," Marks said.

Just that. Two words, and the small dark eyes resting on Jonah like a pair of coins on a dead man's lids.

"Bad luck," Mary said, before Jonah could open his mouth. Smooth. Bored, almost. Not looking up from the map. "Militia rotated the posting early. Six instead of two. Routine. We saw it, we backed off, the weather did the rest. Nobody saw us. Nothing lost but a night."

Let me do the talking. Whatever I say.

Marks didn't look at her. He kept looking at Jonah. Waiting to see if the new hammer had a crack in it.

Jonah held his gaze and said nothing.

"Routine," Marks rumbled at last. He tapped ash. "Six instead of two. Routine." He let the word sit on the table between them like something he hadn't decided whether to eat. Then he shrugged—a tectonic event. "Forget the silk."

"Mary's been filling me in on the Concord haul," Marks said, tapping ash onto the floor. "Forty-two silvers. After her cut. Impressive, for a first-timer." Those small dark eyes fixed on Jonah with the evaluative patience of a man who'd been in the crime business long enough to know that first impressions were usually wrong and second impressions were usually worse. "Means you can move through the Crescent without shitting yourself. That's useful."

"Thanks."

"Wasn't a compliment. It's a job requirement." Marks leaned forward. The table groaned. He tapped the charcoal map with one massive finger. "The Meridian Exchange. Central hub for the northern rail network. Handles all freight manifests, customs declarations, and, more relevantly, the payroll vault for the Communion Rail Authority."

Jonah looked at the map. The building was big—three stories, multiple wings, a rail platform on the east side. A vault was marked in the basement level, behind what looked like two security doors and a guard station.

"Payroll for the entire northern network comes through once a month," Marks continued. "Gold. Not paper, not promissory notes. Actual coin. Forty thousand marks, give or take. It sits in the vault for seventy-two hours before it's distributed to the regional stations."

"You want to rob a government vault," Jonah said.

"I want to rob a government vault," Marks confirmed, as casually as a man ordering lunch. "I need a team. Mary for the planning and the inside work.

You for the Crescent-facing element: the suit, the manners, the ability to walk into a room full of officials without looking like a dock rat. And a few others I'm sourcing." He drew on the cigarillo. "Inside job like this, there's always someone the clerks remember afterwards. The face at the counter. The gentleman who asked about the timetables. Better that face belongs to a man nobody in this city can put a name to."

Jonah caught it: the smallest hitch. Mary's charcoal-smudged finger, tracing the line of the vault corridor, stopped. One heartbeat. Then it moved on, steady as a clock hand, and she didn't look up.

"When?"

"Three weeks. The next payroll shipment arrives on the seventeenth. We plan, we prepare, we execute. Your cut would be—" He glanced at Mary. She held up four fingers without looking up from the map. "Four thousand marks."

Four thousand. Jonah's brain stalled. Four thousand marks was—he didn't even have a frame of reference. It was more than he'd made in his entire life at the Aldworth Foundry. It was enough to buy a house in the merchant quarter. It was enough to—

"I'm in," he said. "But I need to—Mary, can we talk?"

She didn't look up. Her finger was tracing a line on the map, a ventilation shaft, it looked like, running from the ground floor to the basement.

"About what?"

"About—" He glanced at Marks. "Privately."

"I'm busy."

"Mary."

"The ventilation access on the east wing is too narrow for you," she said, still not looking at him. Her voice was flat. Professional. The voice of a woman conducting business, and nothing else, and certainly nothing that had happened in a tent in a storm was relevant to the current proceedings. "We'll need someone smaller for the interior. Marks, what about the Calleni kid, the one who did the Fenwick job last spring—"

"Mary, I need five minutes."

"The Calleni's good," Marks rumbled, ignoring Jonah entirely, which was an impressive feat given that Jonah was sitting three feet away. "But he talks. In a vault job, talking is dying."

"So we tape his mouth. Five coppers and a gag. Problem solved."

"*Mary.*"

She looked up. Finally.

Those green eyes hit him like a slap. Not angry—that he could have handled. Not sad—that he could have worked with. What he saw was worse than either. It was *nothing*. A deliberate, cultivated blankness, like someone had taken everything that had been in those eyes in the tent—the hunger, the vulnerability, the raw, terrifying honesty of *don't break my heart*—and locked it in a box and dropped the box in the harbor.

"We can talk after the briefing," she said. "Marks has the floor plans for another hour before they go back to his source. Priorities."

She looked back down at the map.

Jonah sat through the next forty-five minutes of operational planning with his jaw clenched so tight his molars ached. Marks walked them through the building: guard rotations, shift changes, the seventy-two-hour window, the rail schedules that determined when the platform was empty. Mary asked precise, clinical questions about lock types, vault specifications, and exit routes. She didn't look at Jonah once. Not a glance. Not a flicker. She addressed her comments to Marks, to the map, to the cigarillo smoke drifting through the yellow light. Jonah might as well have been the bench he was sitting on.

When it was over, Marks rolled the map, tucked it inside his coat—it disappeared into the black leather like a mouse into a hole—and stood. The booth exhaled with relief. He dropped two coppers on the table for his gin, nodded at Mary, nodded at Jonah, and walked out, the walking stick *tap-tap-tapping* against the floorboards with each step, the crowd parting for him the way water parts for a ship's hull.

The door closed. The gin house murmured. The bartender wiped a glass.

Mary stood. Gathered her things: a satchel, a knife she kept strapped to the inside of her boot, a half-eaten roll she pocketed without ceremony. She walked toward the door.

"Mary."

She kept walking.

He followed her outside. The Lowers at dusk: the sky going purple above the rail trestles, gaslights flickering to life along the main streets, the air thick with coal smoke and fried fish from a vendor two alleys over. Mary turned left, heading north toward Bent Street, walking fast. Those heeled boots, *tak-tak-tak-tak*, that sharp, quick rhythm he'd recognize anywhere.

"Mary, stop."

"I'm going home."

"You don't have a home. You sleep in four different places depending on who owes you favors."

"Then I'm going to one of the four. Goodnight."

He caught up. Walked beside her. She didn't speed up, didn't slow down, didn't acknowledge his presence. They passed a fishmonger closing his stall. A boy selling evening papers. A drunk pissing against a wall with the carefree aim of a man who'd stopped caring about precision several hours ago.

"About the storm—" he started.

"What storm?"

"The—the *tent*, Mary. The storm. You and me. Last night."

"Last night I was stuck in bad weather during a job that went sideways. I got cold. Body heat was exchanged. Operational necessity." She said it like she was reading from a logistics report. Every word clipped, airtight, sealed with wax. "It happens."

"That's not what happened and you know it."

"Do I?" She turned into an alley, narrow, dark, the walls close enough to touch on both sides. She stopped walking. Turned around. And the blankness cracked.

Not a lot. A hairline fracture. But enough. Underneath it, he could see what was actually there: the same thing he'd seen in the tent, except now it had been through a full day of being ignored and abandoned and confirmed in every suspicion she'd had about herself and about him.

"You went to Lina," she said.

Not a question. A fact. Delivered with the precision of a knife placed on a table.

"Mary—"

"This morning. You didn't go to work. You didn't come find me. You walked your blue balls straight to the Burnt Rose and paid two coppers for someone who actually knows how to suck a cock." Her voice was steady. Her hands were not. They were balled at her sides, knuckles white, nails cutting into her palms. "Did you ask her to wear the shirt again?"

The silence that followed was the loudest thing Jonah had ever heard.

"Sable told you," he said.

"Sable told me you came home smelling like two women and a brothel. I didn't need the specifics. I've got an imagination." She laughed. Short, hard, the sound of glass breaking. "The shirt. You asked her to wear the shirt. My shirt. The linen. And the wig—auburn, right? Because Lina's a professional, she's got wigs, she's got props, she can be anyone you want her to be for two coppers an hour. So you dressed her up like me and you fucked her face the way you couldn't fuck mine because I *gagged*—"

"That's not—"

"DON'T." The word bounced off the alley walls. A cat bolted from a stack of crates. Mary's chest heaved, the oversized shirt rising and falling, and her eyes were bright with something hotter than tears, something that burned rather than flowed. "Don't you *dare* stand there and tell me that's not what happened. I might not be a Crescent lady and I might not be able to deep-throat a cock like a trained courtesan, but I'm not *stupid*, Jonah. Don't insult me by pretending I am."

He didn't say anything. There was nothing to say. She was right. About every word. He had dressed Lina up like her and fucked her as a substitute because Mary's mouth hadn't been enough and his patience hadn't been enough and his own self-control hadn't been enough, and standing here in this alley with the truth of it hanging between them like smoke, he felt something he hadn't felt since the foundry burned.

Shame.

Actual shame. The kind that sits in your stomach like a stone and doesn't move.

"It was a one-time thing," Mary said. Quieter now. The fire banking. Not extinguished—Mary's fire never went out—but tamped down, controlled, directed inward where it would burn slow and steady and do damage only to her. "The tent. You and me. It was a one-time thing. I got cold, you were there, it happened. Operational necessity." She straightened her shoulders. Lifted her chin. "It won't happen again."

"Mary—"

"It *won't happen again*." Each word placed like a brick. Building the wall back up. He could see it going up in real time: the mortar setting, the bricks locking into place, the drawbridge raising. "We work together. Marks has a job. It's a big job and the payout is real and I'm not going to let whatever *this* was —" She gestured between them, a sharp, dismissive flick of the wrist. "—

compromise a four-thousand-mark score. So. We're professionals. We're partners. And what happened in the tent stays in the tent. Dead and buried."

"And if I don't want it dead and buried?"

"Then you should have come to *me* this morning instead of walking to a whorehouse." Her voice cracked on the last word. Just barely. A fissure in the masonry that sealed itself almost immediately. "Anyway. Forget it."

She turned. Walked out of the alley. *Tak-tak-tak-tak.* That rhythm. Those boots. That narrow frame disappearing into the gaslit dusk of the Lowers, shoulders squared, chin up, walking the way she always walked, like she had somewhere to be and you were not invited.

Jonah stood in the alley. The cat crept back onto the crates. The gaslights hissed. Somewhere above, a rail-coach rattled past on its iron trestle, trailing white steam into the purple sky.

Then you should have come to me this morning.

There was no arguing with it. The rightness of it was sitting on his chest like an anvil, and the worst part, the part that made the shame metastasize from his stomach into his throat, was that even now, even standing in this alley with her words still ringing off the bricks, a part of his brain was already wondering when he'd see Jessamine again.

Three women. Two mistakes. One man who wasn't good enough for any of them and was too stupid to stop wanting all three.

He walked home. The Lowers swallowed him the way they swallowed everything: without interest, without judgment, without the faintest suggestion that the city gave a shit about one more man who'd fucked up the only good thing that had happened to him since he'd stepped off a boat with eleven coppers and no plan.

Sable was awake when he got back. Cross-legged by the door. Eating an apple. Where she kept finding apples, he had no idea. Her amber eyes tracked him as he collapsed onto the mattress.

"The angry one came back," she said. "While you were dragging your feet home. Stood outside for six minutes this time. Then she left."

"Six minutes."

"I counted. I count everything." Her ears rotated forward. The curious position, not the hostile one. "She smelled like salt. The kind that comes from eyes, not the sea."

Something in Jonah's chest cracked. Not broke—cracked. The way a load-bearing wall cracks when you put too much weight on one side. Still standing. But compromised.

"Go to sleep, Sable."

"It's barely dusk."

"Then be quiet."

"That's physiologically impossible for me. I'm part cat. We're crepuscular. We're *most* active at dusk."

He put the pillow over his face. It smelled like straw and tallow and the faintest trace of cedar, which was Mary's scent, because she'd been on this mattress the night she planned the ball job and the pillow still held the ghost of her.

Sable chewed her apple. *Crunch. Crunch. Crunch.*

"You're terrible at this," she said. "All of it. Women. Choices. Being a person. Just comprehensively, impressively terrible."

He didn't argue. There was nothing to argue with. The truth doesn't care if you agree with it. It just sits there, crunching an apple, staring at you with amber eyes, waiting for you to catch up.

The gaslight outside the window flickered. The slaughterhouse exhaled its nightly stink. And Jonah Wren lay on a straw mattress in a rented room in a city that owed him nothing, and added *Mary Grieve's tears* to the list of things he'd broken that he didn't know how to fix.

Chapter Nine

Heat



Three days after the alley.

Mary hadn't come by. Hadn't sent word. Hadn't materialized on the steps or in the gin house or at the warehouse where Goss was now docking Jonah half a copper per shift for "unreliability," which was Goss's way of saying *you missed a day and I don't care why*. She was gone—not from Veranesse, because Mary Grieve didn't leave Veranesse, she *was* Veranesse—but from his orbit. Excised. Surgically removed. The ghost-smile, the stolen apples, the sharp green commentary on everything he did wrong—all of it, gone.

He'd looked for her. Checked the Kettle. Checked Rosso's. Checked three of the four places she sometimes slept: a storage room above a sail-maker's, a hammock in the rafters of a decommissioned boathouse, and the back pew of a chapel on the seventh tier where the priest was half-blind and didn't notice squatters. Nothing. Mary Grieve had decided to be unfindable, and when Mary Grieve decided something, the universe generally cooperated.

So he drank.

Not well. Not with any craft or pacing or the controlled self-destruction of a man who knows his limits. He drank the way a fire burns: indiscriminately, consuming whatever was closest, generating heat and waste in equal measure. Dock gin at the Kettle. Something brown and nameless at a place called the Sow's Ear that he didn't remember entering. A bottle of Rekker whiskey

shared with a one-armed sailor on the quay who told him a long story about a woman in the Jade Provinces that Jonah retained exactly none of.

By the time he made it back to Bent Street, the gaslights were doing that thing where they split into two gaslights and then recombined, and the stairs to his room had developed an adversarial relationship with his feet.

Thunk. Knee against the bannister. "*Shit.*"

Creak-creak-creak. The stairs complaining under his weight.

BANG. Shoulder against the doorframe. He hadn't opened the door yet. He was leaning on the wall beside it, forehead pressed against the plaster, breathing. The world tilted. Righted itself. Tilted again.

He got the door open on the second attempt.

The room was dark except for moonlight through the cracked window, cold blue-white light that cut across the floorboards in a long slant and illuminated exactly half of Sable, who was sitting in her spot by the door, knees drawn up, tail curled around her ankles, watching him with those enormous amber eyes that reflected the moon like a pair of coins at the bottom of a well.

"You're drunk," she said.

"Astute." He stumbled to the mattress. Didn't so much sit on it as surrender to it, a controlled collapse that ended with him on his back, one boot on, one boot half-off, his arm thrown across his face. The ceiling spun. He closed his eyes and the spinning got worse. Opened them and the spinning got better but the ceiling looked disappointed in him.

"You've been drinking for—" Sable's nose twitched. Three quick sniffs. "—seven hours. Gin. Whiskey. Something else. Beer, maybe, or something fermented I don't recognize. And you were on the quay for at least an hour because you smell like rope tar and fish."

"Your nose is a miracle of biological engineering and I hate it."

"You also haven't eaten."

"Not hungry."

"You're starving. Your stomach's been growling since you hit the stairs. I could hear it through the door." Her ears were up, the curious position, both triangles angled toward him, tracking his breathing, his heartbeat, the sounds his body made that he couldn't hear himself. "Is this about the angry one? Mary?"

He didn't answer. The arm across his face was doing important work: blocking the moonlight, blocking Sable's gaze, blocking the world in general from seeing whatever was on his face right now.

"It's about the angry one," Sable confirmed. "And the noble. And the woman at the brothel. All three of them. You're drinking because you've made a mess with every woman you've touched since you got here and you don't know how to fix any of it and your solution is to poison yourself with dock gin until the problem goes away." A pause. "The problem won't go away. It'll just have a headache tomorrow."

"Sable."

"What."

"Shut up. Please. Just—for ten minutes. Shut up."

Silence. Merciful, beautiful silence. The slaughterhouse exhaled through the window. A cart rattled past on the street below. The moonlight inched across the floor as the world turned without his permission.

Then he heard her move.

Not the usual shifting: the small adjustments she made in her corner, the tail-repositioning, the ear-twitching. This was different. Deliberate. The soft *pat-pat* of bare feet on floorboards, moving toward him. He felt her weight settle onto the edge of the mattress. Close. The straw compressed under her. He could feel the warmth of her, not touching, but near enough that the heat bridged the gap.

He moved his arm from his face.

She was sitting beside him, cross-legged, looking down at him with an expression he hadn't seen before. Not the hostility. Not the sarcasm. Not the defensive bristle of a creature that had spent its life being grabbed and caged and used. Something softer. Cautious, but softer, like a hand reaching toward a flame, testing the distance.

"You look terrible," she said quietly.

"Thanks."

"No—I mean—" Her ears folded back. Not flat—half-mast. The uncertain position. "You look *hurt*. Like something's broken inside you and you're hoping the alcohol will float the pieces back together." She bit her lip. Her canines pressed into the flesh, sharper than human, leaving small indentations. "I know what that looks like. I've seen it in the mirror."

"Sable—"

"Let me—" She stopped. Started again. Her tail was doing something he'd never seen: curling and uncurling in a slow, rhythmic pattern, like a heartbeat made visible. "Let me help."

"You don't have to help. That's not your job. That's not why I—"

"I know why you freed me. You've told me. Repeatedly. *Ad nauseam.* You're a good man with a savior complex and a guilty conscience and you freed me because slavery is wrong and you believe in sovereignty and it was the right thing to do. I *know*." Her amber eyes held his. The slit pupils were wide in the dark, nearly round, the irises glowing faintly, the way cat eyes glow when the light catches the tapetum behind the retina. "But I'm not doing this because you bought me. I'm doing this because—"

She stopped again. Her cheeks flushed. He could see it even in the moonlight, a darkening across her cheekbones, spreading to the tabby markings on her nose.

"Because what?"

"Because I'm in heat, you *idiot*."

The word landed in the room like a dropped glass.

Jonah blinked. The spinning ceiling paused. "You're—"

"In heat. Yes. It happens. Felinara biology. Every three months, give or take, depending on stress and—and proximity to—" She looked away. Her ears flattened fully. Her tail was lashing now—short, agitated strokes. "To males. Proximity to males accelerates the cycle. And I've been sleeping six feet from you for a *week* and you come home every night smelling like sweat and iron and—and *yourself*, whatever that is, and my body has been—" She pressed her palms against her thighs, hard, like she was trying to hold herself still. "It's been difficult."

"Sable, I can't—you don't owe me—"

"I don't *owe* you anything. I've been very clear about that. This isn't payment. This isn't gratitude. This isn't a cage-girl doing what she's been trained to do." She turned back to face him, and the look in those amber eyes was fierce—the same ferocity he'd seen through the bars of the cage in the Underbelly, except now it was pointed at him, and underneath the ferocity was something raw and trembling and *hungry*. "I've wanted you to touch me since the second night. When you came back from the docks and took your shirt off to wash at the pump and I watched you through the window and I—I *wanted*—and I hated myself for wanting because wanting is what gets you put

in a cage, wanting is how they *control* you, they breed Felinara to want, to need, to go into heat and become compliant and—and I'm not *compliant*, Jonah, I'm not, I'll bite your fucking hand off if you try to *own* me, but I—"

Her voice broke. Not tears. Something more structural. A load-bearing wall giving way.

"I want you to use me," she whispered. "Roughly. The way you used the woman at the brothel. I could *smell* it on you when you came home—the sex, the aggression, the—you were *rough* with her, weren't you? I could smell the —on your hands, the—" Her nostrils flared. Her pupils blew wide. "I want that. I've never had it. I've been *touched*—the traders, the handlers, they touch you when they—to check your teeth, your—" She shuddered. A full-body tremor. "But nobody's ever—I've never been with anyone the way I *want* to be with someone. It's always been hands on me that I didn't choose."

She looked at him with those amber eyes that were wet and blazing.

"I'm choosing you. Right now. While I can still think clearly enough to choose, because in about two hours the heat gets worse and I won't be *choosing* anything, I'll just be *needing*, and I'd rather the first time be a choice."

Jonah sat up. Slowly. The alcohol was still in his blood, but something about the last sixty seconds had burned through the fog like sunlight through cloud cover—not sober, not even close, but *present* in a way he hadn't been all evening.

He looked at her. Really looked.

She was trembling. Not from cold—the night was warm, the room was stuffy—but from the inside out, like something was vibrating beneath her skin at a frequency he couldn't hear. Her copper-auburn hair was mussed, sticking up in choppy tufts around her ears, which were rotating in small circles—forward, back, sideways—processing input from every direction. The cream shift she wore—still the same one, threadbare now, washed in the pump water so many times it had gone translucent at the seams—clung to her small frame in the humidity. He could see the shape of her underneath. The slight curve of small breasts, the narrow waist, the jut of hipbones that were too prominent, the long line of her thighs. Her tail was wrapped around her own wrist, tight, self-restraining, the dark tip twitching.

She smelled different. He couldn't have articulated it if asked—his human nose wasn't built for the subtleties—but there was something new in the air

around her, something warm and musky and sweet that hadn't been there before, like honey left in the sun, like ripe fruit, like *want* made chemical.

"If we do this," he said, "and you want to stop—at any point—"

"I tap twice. I heard you tell Lina." A flicker of the old sarcasm. The ghost of the brat he knew. "The walls in this building are *very* thin, Jonah. I've heard a lot of things."

"You've been—"

"Listening? Yes. Felinara ears. They're not decorative." Her ears perked forward, proving the point. "I've heard you at the pump. I've heard you sleeping. I've heard you—" The flush deepened. "—late at night, when you thought I was asleep. Your hand under the blanket. The sound your breathing makes when you—"

"*Christ*, Sable."

"I didn't look. I wanted to. I didn't."

They stared at each other. The moonlight had moved—it was on the mattress now, cutting between them in a blue-white slash that caught the edge of her jaw and the tip of one copper ear and the glow of her eyes.

He reached out. Slowly. The way you reach toward an animal that might bolt. His hand found the side of her face—his palm against her cheek, fingers curving behind her ear, and she leaned into the touch with an involuntary shudder that moved through her whole body like a wave, and a sound came out of her that he'd never heard a person make.

She purred.

Low, deep, vibrating through her jaw into his palm, through his wrist into his forearm—a resonant, rolling rumble that wasn't a sound so much as a frequency, a vibration that he felt in his teeth and his chest and his cock simultaneously. Her eyes half-closed. Her lips parted. The purring intensified as he moved his thumb across her cheekbone, over the tabby markings, and her head tilted into his hand the way a cat tilts into a scratch, shameless and involuntary and *honest* in a way that human expressions never were.

"You're purring," he said.

"*Shut up.*" Her eyes snapped open. Embarrassment. Fury. The purring didn't stop. "I can't—it's involuntary—I can't *control* it, it just—when someone touches me where I—*shut up*, Jonah."

He kissed her.

She went rigid. Every muscle in her small body locked up—her shoulders, her jaw, her hands—frozen, braced, like she was waiting to be hurt. He held the kiss. Soft. Didn't push. Didn't grab. Just his mouth on hers, warm, still, and his hand on her face, thumb stroking her cheekbone.

Three seconds. Four. Five.

She unlocked. One piece at a time. Shoulders first, dropping. Then her jaw, softening. Then her hands, which had been clenched in the fabric of the shift, releasing and finding his chest, pressing flat, feeling the beat of his heart. And then—all at once, like a dam breaking—she surged forward into him, her mouth opening, her tongue sliding against his, and the purring deepened into something guttural and desperate and the sound she made against his lips —*"Mrrrnnhh"*—was half-human, half-something older, something feral, something bred.

She tasted like apples. Of course she did.

His hands found the hem of the shift. She grabbed his wrists—not stopping him, *guiding* him—pulling his hands up, dragging the fabric with them, and she broke the kiss long enough to pull it over her head and drop it on the floor.

She was naked.

Small. So small. Not fragile—her body was wire and sinew, lean muscle under ivory skin—but *small* in a way that made his hands feel enormous as they settled on her waist, fingers nearly meeting around her. Her breasts were slight—barely enough to cup, pale, with nipples the same dusky pink as her mouth, stiff in the warm air. Her stomach was flat, almost concave, the ribs showing faintly beneath the skin. Her hips were narrow but shaped—the genetic echo of curves that starvation had whittled down. The tabby markings continued down her body—faint, darker-than-skin freckling that traced her collarbones, scattered across her ribs, and thickened slightly at her hipbones in patterns that were almost symmetrical. Between her thighs—copper-auburn, a small neat triangle, already wet. He could see it glistening in the moonlight. He could *smell* it now—that sweet, musky scent, stronger than before, rolling off her in waves.

Her tail unwound from her wrist and swayed behind her—slow, sinuous, the kind of movement she couldn't fake.

"Don't be gentle," she said. Her voice was shaking, but the words were steel. "I know you can be gentle. I've seen it. I don't want gentle. I want—"

Her pupils were fully dilated now, round as coins, the amber almost swallowed by black. "I want what you gave *her*. Lina. I want to feel like someone *wants* me, not like someone's being careful with me."

"You're sure."

"If you ask me if I'm sure one more time I'm going to bite you, and I won't feel bad about it."

He grabbed her.

Both hands around her waist, lifting—she weighed nothing, ninety pounds of fury and need—and she gasped as he pulled her onto his lap, her thighs splitting over his hips, and the contact—her bare cunt against the rough fabric of his trousers, pressing directly onto the hard line of his cock—made her back arch and her claws come out.

Actual claws. Short, curved, sharp as razors, extending from the tips of her fingers involuntarily, and they sank into his shoulders through his shirt and the pain was bright and immediate and he didn't care—he *liked* it—because the small feral creature on his lap was rolling her hips against him and purring so hard the mattress was vibrating and the sounds coming out of her were not human, not entirely, something between a moan and a growl that resonated in his marrow.

"*NnnRRRhhh—Jonah—*"

He yanked his shirt off. Her claws found bare skin. Five points of sharp heat in each shoulder, and she pulled him closer, her small breasts pressing against his chest, her mouth on his neck, biting—not gently, not playfully—*biting*, her elongated canines piercing the skin just above his collarbone, and the pain and the pleasure braided together into something that made his cock throb so hard he could feel his heartbeat in it.

"Harder," she hissed against his throat. "Don't hold back. I'm not *glass*. I'm not—*nnhh*—I'm not breakable—"

He flipped her. One motion—his arm around her waist, rotating, and she was on her back on the mattress with him over her and the straw crunched and the frame groaned and she looked up at him with those enormous black-amber eyes and her copper ears pinned flat and her chest heaving and she was so *small* under him, so slight, his shadow covered her completely—

"*Yes,*" she breathed. "*Like that. Over me. I want to feel your weight—*"

He settled onto her. Not his full weight—he'd crush her—but enough that she felt it, his chest on hers, his hips between her thighs, and she wrapped her

legs around him and locked her ankles at the small of his back and pulled him down and ground upward, her wet cunt dragging along the length of his cock through his trousers, and the friction soaked through the fabric and the heat was staggering.

He undid his trousers. She reached down and helped—her small clawed fingers working the buttons with surprising dexterity, pulling the fabric aside, and her hand closed around him, those curved nails pressing lightly against the shaft—a threat and a caress simultaneously—and she stroked him once, base to tip, her grip tight, her thumb smearing the wetness at the tip, and a sound came out of him that was embarrassing and involuntary and he didn't care.

"Big," she murmured. Not a compliment. An observation. The same tone Lina had used. But where Lina's assessment had been professional, Sable's was —nervous. Calculating. Her amber eyes flicked down, measuring, and he felt her thighs tighten around him, her body tensing with the instinctive caution of a small creature confronting something larger than expected.

"We can go slow—"

"I said *don't be gentle*." She guided him to her entrance. Hot. Slick. The sweet musky scent of her heat was everywhere now—in his nose, on his tongue, soaking into the mattress. "I heal fast. Felinara trait. Just—*do it*."

He pushed in.

Her whole body arched off the mattress. Her mouth opened in a silent scream—no sound, just air, her lungs emptying—and her claws sank into his back, all ten points, and she was *tight*—tighter than Mary, tighter than Lina, an almost painful grip that clenched and released in rhythmic waves that were involuntary, muscular, her body's heat-cycle response to being filled.

"*Ah—AH—*" Sound coming back now, sharp, staccato. "*F-fuck—oh fuck—that's—*"

"Too much?"

"*DON'T STOP.*" Her legs locked tighter. Her hips bucked up. "*Move. Please. Jonah. MOVE.*"

He moved.

Not gentle. She'd asked for not-gentle and he gave her not-gentle—long, deep strokes that drove the breath out of her in punched exhales, his hands pinning her wrists above her head because her claws were shredding the mattress and his back in equal measure, and she writhed beneath him, small and fierce and making sounds that were half-moan, half-growl, the purring

underscoring everything like a bassline—a constant, rumbling vibration that he could feel through his cock, through the walls of her, and it was unlike anything he'd experienced, a *texture* of sensation that was new and overwhelming.

"*NnnRRRhh—harder—HARDER—*"

He gave her harder. The mattress was taking a beating—straw bursting through the seams, the frame slamming against the wall—*THUNK, THUNK, THUNK*—and through the wall the neighbor banged back—*THUMP THUMP*—and Sable laughed, wild and breathless, her head thrown back, ears flat, tail thrashing against the sheets.

"*Let them—hhh—let them hear—I don't—AH—I don't CARE—*"

Her legs tightened around him. Her back arched. Her claws retracted and extended in waves—in, out, in, out—each time pricking his shoulders, his arms, drawing thin lines of blood that he felt as heat. The purring crescendoed—louder, rougher, fragmenting into something ragged and desperate—

She came with a sound that wasn't a scream and wasn't a roar but something between—a high, keening wail that started in her chest and tore upward through her throat and her open mouth and filled the small room and probably the street and definitely the slaughterhouse—"*MRRRAAAHHH—*"—her body clamping down on him so hard he couldn't move, locked inside her, the rhythmic clenching pulling at him in waves, milking, demanding—

He lasted three more strokes. Barely. Her heat-cycle biology was doing something to him—the pheromones, the tightness, the *purring* vibrating through his cock—and when he came he came hard, his face buried in her neck, biting the way she'd bitten him, teeth on the junction of shoulder and throat, and she cried out again—smaller this time, softer—*"Ahhh"*—and her arms wrapped around his head and held him there, teeth and all, as if being bitten was exactly what she'd been waiting for.

Stillness.

The purring continued. Softer now. A rumble. A hum. A lullaby made of vibration and breath.

He lifted his head. She was looking at him. Those amber eyes—enormous, pupils slowly contracting from full-black back to slits as the arousal ebbed—and her face was flushed dark across the cheekbones and her lips were swollen and her copper hair was a disaster and she looked—

Stunned. Like someone who'd been given something they'd stopped believing existed.

"You bit me," she said.

"You bit me first. Multiple times. I'm bleeding."

"That's fair." She touched the mark on her neck. Pressed it. Winced. Smiled. "Do it again next time."

"Next time?"

"The heat lasts three days, Jonah." Her tail curled around his thigh—possessive, anchoring. "You're not sleeping tonight. Or tomorrow night. Or the night after."

She pulled him down and kissed him—softer than before, the ferocity banked, replaced by something warm and slow and almost tender—and he tasted apples and copper and the sweet musk of her heat and the salt of his own blood on her lips.

Outside, the slaughterhouse was silent. The gaslights hissed. The moon had moved past the window, leaving the room in warm darkness, and somewhere down on the waterfront the squeeze-box at the Burnt Rose started up again, wheezing its drunk waltz into the night air.

Sable nestled against his chest. Her ear pressed flat over his heart, listening to it slow. Her purring matched its rhythm—beat for beat, thrum for thrum—as if her body was tuning itself to his.

"Jonah," she murmured.

"Mm."

"Thank you for not being gentle."

He kissed the top of her head, between the ears. She purred harder. Her claws—retracted, this time—kneaded absently against his chest, pressing and releasing, pressing and releasing, an ancient feline reflex that meant comfort, that meant safety, that meant *home*.

He stared at the dark ceiling and felt her heartbeat against his ribs and added a fourth face to the spinning carousel behind his eyes—amber, now, alongside green and navy and brown—and the ceiling didn't spin, and the alcohol had burned off, and the shame was still there but it had moved over to make room for something else. Something with claws and a purr and a smart mouth and a tail wrapped around his thigh like she was afraid he'd leave in the night.

He wasn't going anywhere. Not tonight. Not for three days, apparently.

The city hummed. The straw mattress held. And Sable's purring filled the room like a second heartbeat, steady and sure and asking for nothing except exactly what she'd already been given.



He woke to the smell of apples and heat.

Not temperature heat—though the room was stuffy, the afternoon sun baking through the cracked window and turning the air thick and golden. *Her* heat. That sweet, musky, pheromone-drenched scent that had soaked into the mattress, the sheets, his skin, everything. It was stronger today—Day Two, she'd told him, was the peak—and it hit his hindbrain like a fist, his cock stiffening before his eyes were fully open.

Sable was sitting cross-legged at the foot of the mattress. Naked. Unselfconscious in a way she hadn't been last night—the shift discarded somewhere, her small ivory body bare in the afternoon light, the tabby markings on her cheekbones and ribs catching the sun in patterns that looked almost deliberate, like someone had painted them. Her copper ears were up, swiveling gently, and her tail swayed behind her in that slow, sinuous rhythm that meant she was thinking.

She was eating an apple. Because of course she was.

"You're staring," she said, without looking at him.

"You're naked."

"I've been naked for twelve hours. You've been inside me for most of them. The staring ship has sailed." *Crunch.* She chewed. Swallowed. Those amber eyes slid to him. The pupils were dilated—not fully, but wider than daytime warranted. The heat, working on her from the inside. "I know why you and Mary aren't talking."

Jonah rubbed his face. His back was on fire—her claws had left a roadmap of scratches across his shoulders and ribs that stung when he moved. His neck had bite marks. His thighs had bruises from her heels. Three rounds in one night with a Felinara in heat was apparently the biological equivalent of being mugged by a very affectionate wildcat.

"Sable—"

"She tried to do the throat thing. The eastern technique. She couldn't. She gagged and felt humiliated and you went to Lina because Lina can take it and Mary can't, and Mary found out and now she hates you." She bit the apple.

Crunch. Matter of fact. Like she was reading weather. "The walls are thin. I told you."

"You heard—"

"Everything. Every conversation, every argument, every time she sat on the steps outside deciding whether to knock. I hear *everything*, Jonah. These—" She flicked one copper ear. "—aren't decorative. I heard you in the tent. I heard her gagging. I heard her crying in the alley." A pause. The tail stopped swaying. "I heard you at Lina's. Through the *building*. I heard the table."

He stared at the ceiling. The plaster crack that looked like a coastline. His old friend.

"Why are you telling me this?"

Sable set the apple core on the floor. Licked her fingers—a quick, feline motion, her tongue darting between each fingertip. She turned to face him fully, those enormous amber eyes catching the afternoon light and throwing it back in coins of liquid gold.

"Because you don't have to pay Lina to dress up like someone else anymore." Her voice was steady. Controlled. But he could see the flush building across her cheekbones—darker, spreading, the tabby marks disappearing into it. "I can do what she does. Better."

"Sable, you don't have to—"

"If you finish that sentence—*that is not why I freed you*—I'm going to claw your face off. I've heard it. I know it. It's engraved on my brain. You freed me because you're a good man with a messiah complex. Wonderful. Noted. Tattooed on my heart. *Moving on.*" She crawled toward him. On all fours. The movement was—not human. Not entirely. Her spine undulated with a fluidity that no human spine possessed, her hips swaying, her tail raised and curling at the tip, and there was something primal and ancient in the way she moved that bypassed every civilized circuit in his brain and went straight to the base of his skull where the lizard lived.

She stopped between his legs. Knelt. Looked up at him with those slit-pupil eyes and that serious, angular face and the copper hair falling in choppy tufts around her ears.

"The Felinara pleasure houses in the old empire trained their courtesans differently than the human ones," she said. "My mother was trained. Before she escaped. Before—" A shadow. Quick, shuttered, filed away. "She taught me things. Techniques. Not because she wanted me to be a whore, but

because she said a woman who controls a man's pleasure controls the man, and a Felinara who can't control the men around her ends up in a cage."

"Your mother taught you—"

"The Scorpion." She said it like a title. A proper noun. "It's a throat technique. The eastern method you like—the *irrumatio*—it goes deep, but the woman's throat fights it. The gag reflex. The tightness. Even Lina—she's good, but she's managing the reflex, not eliminating it. She's fighting her own body to let you in."

"And the Scorpion?"

Sable's tail curled slowly behind her. Her pupils dilated another fraction. The heat was building—he could smell it, could see it in the flush spreading down her neck to her chest.

"The Felinara throat is different. Longer. More flexible. We have a secondary soft palate—here—" She touched her own throat, just below the jaw. "—that humans don't. In the old empire, the courtesans trained to *invert* the reflex. Instead of the throat tightening to push you out, it opens—pulls you in. The muscles work *with* the penetration instead of against it. Deeper than any human throat can take. And the technique—" She shifted her weight. Her hands moved to his thighs, palms flat, warm. "—the Scorpion—involves positioning. I go upside down. Head off the edge of the bed, throat perfectly aligned, straight line from my mouth to my chest. Gravity does half the work. The angle eliminates the gag entirely. And I lock my legs around your head."

"You—"

"Like a scorpion's tail. Curling over. Locking you in place so you can't pull back even if you want to." Her claws extended—just the tips—and pricked lightly against his thighs. "You said you wanted control. The *irrumatio* gives you control of the pace. The Scorpion gives you control of *everything*. Depth. Duration. Force. And my throat will take it. All of it. As deep as you can reach."

She looked up at him. The flush was full now—her cheeks, her neck, her chest, the small pale breasts with their dusky nipples visibly stiffened. The musk of her heat rolled off her in waves that made his head swim. Her pupils were nearly round, the amber reduced to a thin ring of fire around black pools.

"I'm not Mary," she said softly. "I'm not going to gag and cry and feel humiliated. And I'm not Lina wearing someone else's hair. I'm *me*. And I can take everything you have."

Jonah's cock was so hard it was pulsing visibly, each heartbeat sending a throb through the shaft that Sable's eyes tracked with the focused precision of a predator watching prey.

"Show me," he said.



She repositioned. Quick, efficient, the movements precise—she'd been thinking about this. She lay on her back on the mattress, then slid upward until her head hung off the edge, her copper hair dangling toward the floor, her throat stretched long and straight—a clean, unbroken line from her open mouth down through her neck. Her back arched slightly, her small breasts pointing toward the ceiling, her stomach taut, her legs drawn up with her knees bent.

From above, the angle was—*Christ*. He could see straight down into her open mouth. The pink of her tongue, flat and waiting. The back of her throat, relaxed, open. The architecture of her—the secondary palate she'd described, visible as a slight thickening behind the uvula, already shifting, the muscles rearranging themselves in a way no human throat could replicate.

He stood at the edge of the bed. Looked down at her. She was upside down, her amber eyes looking up at his cock from below, and from this angle her face was alien and beautiful and completely, terrifyingly open.

"Whenever you want," she said. Her voice was calm. Her tail was not—it was lashing against the sheets in rapid strokes. "Go as deep as you want. As hard as you want. I'll lock on when you're in."

He took her jaw in one hand. Tilted her head back another degree. The line of her throat was perfectly straight—he could see the pulse in her neck, rapid, and the slight movement of her swallowing, and the way her secondary palate *opened* as she relaxed into the position, the muscles dilating like an iris.

He guided himself to her lips. The head of his cock rested on her lower lip—she was upside down, so the geometry was reversed, and the tip pressed against the flat of her tongue, which curled up—*down*, from her perspective—to cradle it.

He pushed in.

The first two inches were familiar—the wet heat of a mouth, the pressure of lips, the texture of tongue. Standard. Known.

Then he hit the back of her throat and everything changed.

Instead of tightening—instead of the clench and fight and *GHHK* that he'd felt with Lina and Mary—her throat *opened*. The muscles dilated in a wave, a rippling expansion that pulled him deeper, and the sensation was—his brain short-circuited trying to categorize it. Not just heat. Not just pressure. A *pull*. An active, muscular suction that drew his cock downward—from his perspective—into a channel that was tighter than anything he'd ever felt but *welcoming*, the muscles working with him instead of against him, and he slid deeper—four inches, five, six—until his entire shaft was buried in her throat and his balls pressed against the bridge of her upside-down nose and he could *see* it—

The bulge. In her throat. The shape of his cock, visible through the pale skin of her neck, a distension that moved as he moved, and the sight of it—the visual evidence of how deep he was, the physical proof of her body accommodating him—made something snap in his brain.

"*Holy f—*"

Her legs came up. Fast. Her thighs clamped around his head—ankles crossing behind his skull, heels locking against the back of his neck—and she pulled him *down*, her entire lower body curling over him like the tail of a scorpion, and he was trapped. Locked. His face pressed between her thighs—he could smell her heat, overwhelming at this range, feel the slick wet heat of her cunt against his chin—and his cock was buried to the root in her throat and her legs held him there and the sound she made was not a gag, not a choke, but a deep, vibrating *purr* that traveled the length of his shaft and detonated at the base of his spine.

"*NNGH—FUCK—SABLE—*"

He grabbed her. Lost it. Every thread of restraint, every careful modulation, every *are you sure* and *we can go slow*—gone. Burnt. Ash. He grabbed her throat—one hand wrapped around the column of her neck, feeling his own cock through her skin, feeling the bulge, feeling the muscles of her throat rippling around him—and he grabbed her hip with the other hand, fingers digging into the bone, and he started to thrust.

Not slow. Not careful. Not measured.

He fucked her throat with the accumulated fury of every frustrated, denied, complicated, shame-soaked moment since he'd stepped off the *Harren's Wake*. Deep, brutal strokes that pushed the bulge in her throat down toward her chest and pulled it back, and the sounds were inhuman—wet, guttural, a churning *GLRK, GLRK, GLRK* that was louder and wetter and more obscene than anything he'd produced with Lina because this was *deeper*, this was past where human anatomy allowed, this was the full length of him disappearing into a throat that was built—*bred*—for this.

Her legs tightened around his head. The scorpion lock—her thighs crushing his ears, her ankles crossed at his nape, pulling him deeper with every thrust. He couldn't pull out even if he wanted to. She had him. Her heels dug into the base of his skull, her calves flexed against his jaw, and every time he drove in deep, her legs *pulled*, adding force, driving him that last impossible inch until his pelvis slammed against her face with a wet *SMACK* and her throat bulged and her purring vibrated through every inch of buried cock.

"*FUCK—Jesus—FUCK—*"

Spit was running—everywhere. Down her face, into her hair, pooling on the floor beneath her dangling head. Her eyes were squeezed shut, tears streaming from the corners—not pain, not distress, the involuntary waterworks of a throat being used at maximum capacity—and her hands were on his thighs, claws out, all ten points sunk into the muscle, anchoring, holding, not pushing away, *pulling closer*.

He looked down. Watched his cock slide in and out of her upside-down mouth. Watched her throat expand and contract around him. Watched the bulge travel up and down the column of her neck with each stroke. The visual was so filthy, so *anatomically explicit*, that his orgasm started building from a place he didn't know existed—deeper than his balls, deeper than his groin, somewhere in the base of his spine where the most primitive wiring lived.

He sped up. Lost what was left of his rhythm. Pure animal—hips jackhammering, hands gripping her throat and her hip, the mattress sliding across the floor, the frame slamming the wall—*BANG BANG BANG BANG* —and Sable took every stroke without flinching, her throat opening and closing around him in that impossible rippling wave, her purring now a roar, a vibration so intense it was almost painful, her legs locked around his skull like a vice—

"*I'm—Sable—I can't—I'm going to—*"

Her legs pulled. *Hard*. Crushing him in. Her hands left his thighs and grabbed his ass—claws and all, ten points of sharp heat sinking into the muscle—and she yanked him forward and held him there, buried to the root, his cock lodged so deep in her throat that the bulge sat below her jaw, and she *swallowed*.

Not a reflex. A *technique*. A deliberate, rhythmic, rolling contraction of her throat muscles around his shaft—squeeze, release, squeeze, release—milking him, pulling at him, the muscles working in waves from the base of his cock to the tip and back, and the sensation was so far beyond anything he'd experienced that language failed and thought failed and everything failed except the white-hot supernova detonating at the base of his spine.

He came.

Not like the other times. Not like Lina, not like Mary, not like any woman or any hand or any desperate Atlantic-crossing fantasy. This was different in *kind*—a full-body seizure that started in his balls and rolled up his spine and out through every extremity simultaneously, his hands locking on her throat, his hips stuttering, his vision whiting out completely as he pulsed—once, twice, three times, four, five—each one a convulsion that emptied him deeper into her throat than he'd known was possible, and she swallowed every pulse, her throat working around him in perfect synchronization, the muscles contracting with each spurt, pulling it down, taking it, *draining* him—

"*AHHH—FUCK—FUCK—SABLE—FUUUCK—*"

His knees buckled. Genuinely buckled. He caught himself on the edge of the mattress with one hand, the other still on her throat, and he could feel the last pulses through her skin—his cock twitching, emptying, the final tremors rolling through muscle that was wrung dry and still clenching.

Her legs slowly unlocked. Her thighs released his head—his ears rang in the sudden absence of pressure. Her ankles uncrossed. Her legs lowered to the mattress.

He pulled out. Slow. Inch by inch. The withdrawal was almost as intense as the act—her throat releasing him in stages, the muscles letting go one ring at a time, a slow, slick, obscene extraction that produced a sound—*glllllk*—long and wet and final.

He staggered backward. Hit the wall. Slid down it until he was sitting on the floor, naked, legs splayed, chest heaving, every muscle in his body

trembling with the particular exhaustion of a man who has just been emptied so completely that his skeleton feels optional.

Sable rolled over on the mattress. Slowly. She was a mess—spit and tears covering her face, her hair matted and wet, her throat visibly reddened, her eyes swollen. She coughed once—*khh*—cleared her throat, wiped her face with the back of her hand, and looked at him.

She was smiling. Not the brat's smirk. Not the defensive snarl. A real smile—exhausted, proud, and *satisfied* in a way that went deeper than the physical.

"So," she rasped. Her voice was wrecked. Barely there. A whisper scraped across sandpaper. "Still thinking about Lina?"

He couldn't answer. He couldn't form words. His brain was a smoking crater where cognitive function used to live.

Sable sat up. Winced—touched her throat, probed gently. Her accelerated healing was already working—the redness was fading, the swelling diminishing even as he watched. Felinara biology. Extraordinary.

She crawled to the edge of the mattress. Looked down at him on the floor. Those amber eyes—softer now, the pupils slowly contracting back to slits, the fierceness banked. Her tail swayed behind her in slow, contented arcs.

"My mother said the Scorpion was the technique that kept empresses loyal and emperors on their knees." She tilted her head. That feline head-tilt—curious, appraising. "I think she was right."

She extended one small hand. He took it. She pulled—or tried to, she weighed ninety pounds and had the leverage of a child—and he hauled himself up and collapsed onto the mattress beside her and she curled into him immediately, her face against his chest, her ear over his heart, her tail wrapping around his thigh, and the purring started up again—low, steady, a satisfied frequency that resonated through his ribs and settled somewhere behind his sternum.

"Day Two," she murmured against his skin. "We've got tonight and all of tomorrow."

"I might not survive tomorrow."

"You'll survive. You're built like a draft horse. Lina was right about that." She nuzzled deeper into his chest. Her claws kneaded—retracted, gentle, pressing and releasing against his pectoral. "Jonah?"

"Mm."

"Don't go back to Lina for this. Come to me." Her purring deepened. "I'll always take you deeper."

He stared at the ceiling. The coastline crack. The afternoon light. The slaughterhouse stink drifting through the window, somehow less offensive than usual, or maybe his nose had finally surrendered.

Four women. Two he'd hurt. One who charged by the hour. And one who was purring against his chest with her tail around his thigh and her claws gentle on his skin and her ruined voice making promises his body was already signing contracts for.

He closed his eyes. Sable purred. The city hummed.

He slept.



When he woke, the light had gone copper and low, sliding in sideways through the cracked window, and Sable was sitting on the sill.

She'd put on one of his shirts. It hung to her knees, sleeves rolled four times and still swallowing her wrists, her tail curled out from under the hem and draped down the wall. She had her knees drawn up and her chin on them, and she was watching the rail trestles where the evening coaches ran north, one after another, trailing white steam into a sky going the color of a bruise.

The heat came in tides, she'd told him sometime around dawn. This was low water. He could see it in her: the pupils back to slits, the flush gone from her cheeks, something in her shoulders sharp and awake again. The Sable he knew. The one who counted everything.

"I followed you," she said, without turning around. "The night you went to the gin house."

He sat up. His back screamed. "You—*what*?"

"There's a drainpipe behind the Kettle. Goes right up past the back booth to the roof. I lived in a pipe for a year, Jonah, I can climb a drainpipe." Her ear rotated toward him. "I heard all of it. The big man. The building. The vault in the basement. Forty thousand marks." A pause. "The shaft that's too narrow for you."

He didn't say anything.

"And I heard him say the clerks remember a face. And that it should be a face nobody can name." Now she turned. Those amber eyes, flat and serious in the copper light. "I hear heartbeats, Jonah. Not just yours. When he said that,

the angry one's heart went like a rabbit's. Just for a second. Then she made it stop."

"What does that mean?"

"I don't know what it means. I know what it *sounds* like." She looked back out the window. A coach rattled past on the trestle, its lamps sliding across her face. "He also said the building handles freight manifests. Every cargo that rides the northern rail gets written down in there."

"So?"

"So the Khett don't sell us in markets and walk us home on leads, idiot. Not the ones they sell up the hill. They ship us. Crated. On the rail. And on the paper it says *livestock*, or *labor stock*, or *goods, perishable*." Her voice didn't shake. That was the worst part: how steady it was. "My mother got caught when I was nine. They took her north. I watched the coach go. If she went up the hill to some house with a silver leaf on its gates, then she went on paper first. And the paper is in that building."

The room was very quiet. The slaughterhouse breathed its evening breath through the window.

"I fit," Sable said. "The shaft. I fit."

"No."

"You haven't heard—"

"I heard enough. *No.*" He was on his feet before he'd decided to stand. "I didn't take you out of a cage so somebody could feed you down a hole in the Communion's basement. That's—that's *exactly* what they bred your people for, Sable. Small ones for tight spaces. Mary said it the first night I asked about you. You think I'm going to stand there and be the man who—"

"You don't get a vote."

It stopped him.

She unfolded from the sill. Dropped to the floor without a sound. Walked to him in his own shirt with her tail low and her chin up, the same walk she'd used leaving the cistern, like she already owned the floor under her feet.

"You didn't buy me," she said. "Remember? You bought your conscience. That was yours. This part is mine." She stopped close enough that she had to tip her head all the way back to hold his eyes. "Nobody is using me. I'm *choosing*. Same as last night. I told you then I wanted it to be a choice while I could still make one. So is this."

He looked down at her. Ninety pounds of wire and fury and grief she'd kept so well hidden he'd never once thought to ask about it.

Big ones for heavy lifting. Small ones for tight spaces.

He reached for his boots.

"Where are you going?" she said.

"To find Mary."

"She doesn't want to see you."

"She's going to have to." He yanked the laces tight. "If she's hiding something about this job, I want it out of her before anybody climbs into anything."

Sable was already at the door. She'd pulled on the rough-spun shift under his shirt and had her bare feet set on the threshold, ears up, tail flicking, *flick, flick*—the metronome counting down.

"Then I'm coming," she said.

He opened his mouth to argue. She was already on the stairs.

Chapter Ten

The Fourth Place



The Lowers at dusk smelled like fish frying in old fat and coal smoke settling into the streets the way silt settles in a jar. The gaslamps were coming on one at a time along Bent Street. *Tick, hiss, pop.* A lamplighter on a ladder working his way north with a pole and a cough that sounded like a rail brake.

Sable walked three steps ahead of him. Barefoot. His shirt belted at her waist with a length of twine she'd stolen from Rosso's counter on the way out. She kept her head down and her ears pinned flat under a scrap of headscarf, because ears drew eyes and eyes drew trouble, and a Felinara walking free in the Lowers after dark was the kind of thing men noticed and remembered and sometimes acted on.

"Sail-maker's first," Jonah said. "Then the boathouse. Then—"

"She's not at any of them."

"You don't know that."

"I know you checked all three yesterday. Twice. You came home smelling like tar, river mud, and candle wax." She didn't turn around. "She's somewhere you haven't been."

"There's a fourth place. I don't know where."

"I do." Now she looked back. Those amber eyes in the lamplight, flat gold coins. "Cedar shavings and steel. That's her. I've smelled it on your pillow for a week. I can follow that through a fish market."

He didn't argue. There was no point arguing with Sable about things her nose had already decided.

She led him east, away from the water. Through the tanners' yards, where the stink of lime pits made his eyes run. Under the first of the rail trestles, a great black spine of riveted iron that cut the Lowers in half and dripped condensation on everyone who walked beneath it. Past a row of shuttered pawnshops and a gin cellar where somebody was singing a Rekker drinking song with no regard for key or decency.

Every forty yards or so she'd stop. Lift her face. Breathe in through her nose in short sharp pulls—*sff, sff, sff*—and her ears would twitch under the headscarf, and she'd turn a corner he'd never have chosen.

"You could make a living at this," he said.

"I did. Finding things people dropped. Mostly fish." *Sff, sff.* "Left."

The streets got worse as the ground rose. Not poorer—the Lowers were all poor—but emptier. Fewer lit windows. More boarded doors. They were coming up into the rail yards now, the great flat sprawl of sidings and switching tracks and coal stacks that sat between the Lowers and the merchant quarter like a no-man's-land. Steam rose from somewhere and hung low and orange under the gaslamps. A locomotive idled on a far track, breathing—*chuff... chuff... chuff*—the slow, enormous patience of a sleeping animal.

And on the far side of the yards, rising out of the steam three stories high, lit up like a lantern at every window: the Meridian Exchange.

Jonah stopped walking.

He'd seen the map. Charcoal on brown paper. He hadn't seen *this*. Grey stone and iron, a clock tower at the north corner with a face as big as a cartwheel, a glass-roofed platform along the east wing where the freight coaches pulled in. Two Communion militia stood at the main doors with rifles. Two more walked the platform. Even from here he could see the building did not sleep.

"That's it," Sable said quietly beside him. "Isn't it."

"That's it."

She stared at it for a long moment. He watched her look at the windows. Count them, maybe. Wonder which one had her mother written down behind it in somebody's tidy ledger hand. *Goods, perishable.*

Then she turned away and pointed up.

"There."

At the edge of the yards, backing onto the coal stacks, stood a coal loft, a tall timber shed on stilts, three stories of blackened planking, built to feed fuel down chutes into waiting tenders. Half its windows were boarded. At the very top, under the eaves, one wasn't.

There was a light in it. Small. Steady. A single candle.

The ladder was on the inside, nailed to the wall, every rung slick with coal dust. Jonah climbed with his palms going black and his shoulders scraping the planking. Sable went up the outside of the building instead—he didn't see how, just heard the soft *tk-tk-tk* of claws finding grain in old wood—and was waiting at the top when he hauled himself through the hatch, sitting cross-legged on a beam like she'd been there an hour.

The room under the eaves was small. Low ceiling, pitched roof, a straw tick on the floor with a grey army blanket folded on it with almost military precision. A crate for a table. A tin cup. A candle stub on a saucer.

And the walls.

Every inch of the walls was covered.

Brown paper, pinned with nails. Charcoal drawings: the Meridian from the front, the side, the platform, the clock tower. Floor plans, some of them the same as Marks's map and some of them *not*—more detailed, annotated in a small cramped hand. Guard rotations, written in columns, times crossed out and rewritten. Rail timetables torn from the public boards and marked up in red chalk. A drawing of a uniform, militia issue, every button counted. A drawing of a vault door, the dial rendered so carefully you could see the numbers.

Some of the paper was fresh. Some of it was old enough that the edges had curled and gone yellow and the charcoal had smudged soft under the oil of a hundred touches.

Months, Jonah thought. Not weeks. *Months.*

Marks had pitched the Meridian four days ago.

Mary was sitting on the crate with her back to the far wall and her knife in her hand.

She didn't point it at him. She was using it to pare an apple, the peel coming off in one long unbroken red curl, and she didn't stop when he came through the hatch, and she didn't look up.

"You brought the cat," she said.

"She brought me."

"Of course she did." The peel dropped. She cut a slice, ate it off the knife. "Felinara nose. I should've slept somewhere that smelled worse."

Sable said nothing. She was perfectly still on her beam, tail wrapped around it, eyes half-lidded. But Jonah saw her nostrils flare once, and he saw Mary see it, and he saw something pass across Mary's face that she put away very fast.

"Mary."

"Say what you came to say. I've got work."

He looked at the walls. At the yellowed paper. At the vault door drawn so lovingly it might have been a portrait.

"How long?" he said.

The knife paused. Just for a second.

"How long have you been watching that building, Mary? Because that drawing"—he pointed at the oldest of them, the clock tower, the charcoal gone grey and soft—"that's not from this month. That's not from this *season*."

She set the apple down on the crate. Set the knife down next to it. Wiped her fingers on her trousers. All of it slow, deliberate, the way you'd move around a dog you didn't know.

"Since spring," she said.

"Marks pitched it four days ago."

"Marks pitched it to *you* four days ago." She finally looked up. The green eyes weren't blank anymore. They were tired. They were the eyes of somebody who'd been carrying something heavy uphill a long time and had just been asked to set it down in front of strangers. "I pitched it to him in the summer. He didn't bite. Said it was too big, too clean, too close to the Authority. Then two months ago he comes back and says he's been thinking. Says he's found a way. Says all he needs is the right face."

The right face. Nobody in this city can put a name to it.

"And then I walk off a boat," Jonah said.

"And then you walk off a boat." She laughed, without anything in it. "Eleven coppers and a jaw like a shovel and no one in Veranesse who'd know you from a lamp-post. You were *perfect*, Jonah. I knew it the second I grabbed your coat. That's why I didn't let you go."

The candle hissed. Below them, somewhere in the yards, a coupling banged —*KLANG*—and the whole loft shivered on its stilts.

"You set me up."

"I *found* you." Sharp. "That's different. I found you, and I fed you to Marks one piece at a time, and I watched him like what he saw, and then I spent four days hearing him talk about faces and clerks and witnesses and I—" She stopped. Breathed. Picked the knife back up and turned it over in her fingers without looking at it. "I didn't think I'd care. All right? That's the truth. When I picked you off the docks you were a coat with a body in it. I didn't plan on the tent. I didn't plan on any of it."

"The guards at the station."

"Not me."

"Mary—"

"*Not me.*" The knife stopped turning. "I was in that bracken next to you. You think I'd sell a job I'm lying in? Somebody wanted to know if you'd run or fight or squeal when it went bad. Somebody wanted to see what you were made of before they trusted you with forty thousand marks." Her mouth twisted. "Marks tests things. Hammers. Knives. People."

From the beam, quiet as dust settling, Sable said: "She's telling the truth."

Mary's head snapped around.

"About the guards," Sable said. "Her heart's steady. It wasn't steady at the gin house when the big man said *face*. It's steady now." She tilted her head. "It went funny a minute ago, when she said *tent*. But that's a different thing."

The silence after that could have been cut and sold by the pound.

"I'm going to throw something at her," Mary said, very calmly.

"She'll catch it," Jonah said.

"I'll catch it," Sable agreed.

Mary looked at the cat-girl on the beam for a long moment. At the shirt Sable was wearing—*Jonah's* shirt, belted with twine. At the bite mark showing purple at the edge of the collar, just under one copper ear. Mary's nostrils flared, and she didn't have a Felinara nose, but she didn't need one. Her jaw went tight enough to crack a walnut.

Then she turned back to Jonah, and whatever she'd felt she'd already nailed to a wall somewhere inside and left there with the timetables.

"What do you want," she said.

"The truth about Marks. All of it. What he's holding over you."

"No."

"Mary."

"*No.*" She stood up. She was a full head shorter than him and the ceiling was low enough that he had to stoop and somehow she still managed to look down at him. "You want to know about the job, fine. I'll tell you about the job. You want to know about me, you can go to the Burnt Rose and pay Lina to dress up and *tell* you."

That landed. She meant it to.

He took it. Stood there under the eaves with coal dust on his hands and took it, because she'd earned the right to throw it.

"Marks has paper on somebody," she said, quieter. "Somebody I love. Indenture. Old-style, from before the Communion—the kind they said they abolished and didn't. As long as he holds it, I work for him. When the Meridian's done, he burns it. That's the deal. That's all you get."

"And me?"

She held his eyes.

"When the Meridian's done," she said, "Marks gets forty thousand marks and the Authority gets a face to hang. You were supposed to be a long way gone before anyone came asking. Or you weren't. Marks didn't much care which." Something moved in her throat. "I was going to tell you. After. Get you on a boat. I had it worked out."

"Did you."

"I've got *everything* worked out, Jonah. Look at the fucking walls."

He looked at the walls.

Months of charcoal. Months of counting buttons on a guard's coat. Months of a woman sitting up here alone in a coal loft above the rail yards with a candle stub and a tin cup, drawing the same building over and over until she could walk it blind. Not for Marks. Marks hadn't wanted it.

For whoever was on that paper.

"I'm still in," he said.

Mary blinked.

"The job. I'm still in."

"Did you hear a single word I—"

"I heard all of them. Marks wants a face to hang. Fine. Then we make sure there isn't one to find." He jerked his chin at the vault door drawing. "You

know that building better than he does. Better than anyone. You don't need his plan. You need a crew that isn't planning to sell you out at the end."

She stared at him. Behind her eyes he could see it: the machinery spinning up, odds running, the quick ugly arithmetic of a woman who'd lived her whole life calculating what she could survive.

"And the cat?" she said finally.

"The cat fits in your shaft," said Sable.

Mary turned slowly to look at her.

"The east wing ventilation," Sable said. "It's too narrow for him. It isn't too narrow for me. I heard you at the Kettle." Her tail unwound from the beam and swung, once. "I want something in that building too. It isn't gold. You can have the gold."

"What, then?"

"Paper," said Sable. "Same as you."



They came back down Bent Street a little after ten, the three of them, not talking.

Mary hadn't agreed to anything. She'd said *I need to think*, which in Mary's language meant *I've already decided and I need to find out whether I like what I decided*. She'd walked out of the coal loft with them anyway, and she was walking beside him now with her hands jammed in her trouser pockets and her eyes on the cobbles, and every so often her shoulder brushed his arm and neither of them moved away.

Sable walked ahead. Ears up under the headscarf. Tail swishing.

At the foot of the chandler's stairs she stopped dead.

Her nose went up. *Sff. Sff.* Her whole body went rigid, then low, the way a cat drops when something bigger has come into the yard. The fur along her tail stood up in a ridge.

"Someone's in your room," she whispered.

Jonah's hand went to the knife at his belt. Mary's went to her boot.

"How many?"

"One." *Sff.* "Cedar oil. Orange peel." Sable's lips peeled back from her teeth. "Rich-house soap."

Mary looked at Jonah.

Jonah was already climbing.

The door was unlocked. He hadn't left it unlocked.

He pushed it open with two fingers and the hinges groaned—*rrrrrnnn*—and the candle on the windowsill was lit, which he also hadn't done, and sitting on the end of his straw mattress, with her ankles crossed and her gloved hands folded in her lap and the slaughterhouse breathing in through the cracked window behind her, was Jessamine Ashburn.

No emerald silk tonight. A plain wool cloak the color of wet slate, hood pushed back. Under it a dark riding habit buttoned to the throat, expensive, severe, the kind of thing a woman wore when she wanted to be taken for somebody's governess at a distance and nobody's governess up close. No diamonds. Her mahogany hair pinned low and simple at the nape. She'd done something to her face, too, washed it of everything, so that the freckles stood out across her nose like a scatter of cinnamon. She looked younger like this. She looked, if anything, more dangerous.

She looked at the knife in his hand. Then at his face.

"Mr. Wren," she said. "Your landlord is a deeply unpleasant man. He let me up for a silver and then tried to sell me a candle for another." She glanced at the candle on the sill. "I bought it. It seemed rude not to."

Behind him, Mary came through the door like a thrown blade and stopped so short Sable nearly walked into her back.

Jessamine's navy eyes moved past him. Took Mary in—head to boots, the oversized shirt, the patched corset, the knife half drawn from the boot-sheath—in about a second and a half. Took Sable in, too: the headscarf, the bare dirty feet, the tail now bristled to twice its size and lashing. Nothing moved on Jessamine's face. Not a flicker.

"Miss Grieve," she said. "And—I'm sorry, I don't know your name."

Sable hissed. Actually hissed—*HHHAAAHHH*—a long ragged sound from the back of her throat, ears flat, teeth out.

"Sable," Jonah said. "Her name's Sable."

"Sable." Jessamine inclined her head. A small, exact courtesy, the same she'd have given a duchess. "I'm sorry. I gather my family has given you very good reason to dislike the smell of me."

The hiss cut off. Sable stared at her.

Mary found her voice. "How the *fuck* do you know my name?"

"The same way I knew where Mr. Wren lives." Jessamine reached into her cloak—slowly, with a glance at Mary's knife that said she understood exactly how slowly she ought to do it—and drew out a folded square of paper. She held it up between two gloved fingers. "I bought it."

Jonah's stomach turned over.

"There is a woman at an establishment called the Burnt Rose," Jessamine said, "who has been receiving visits from Captain Aldric Thorne. Captain Thorne has been offering twenty silvers for the true name and lodging of the man who attended the Concord as Lord Ashmore Vell." She set the folded paper down on the mattress beside her. "I offered forty. And a promise that I would find out if she sold it twice."

Not yet. Price goes up if you wait.

Lina had waited. And then she'd sold it to the highest bidder.

"So Thorne doesn't have it," Jonah said.

"Thorne doesn't have it. Thorne has a wire from the eastern provinces confirming that the real Lord Vell has not left Harrowgate in two years, a coatroom full of furious guests, and a hole in his evening where your name should be." She smoothed her glove over her knee. "He's a patient man and a vindictive one, and he will keep digging. But for now, Mr. Wren, the only person in Veranesse who can hang you is sitting on your mattress."

The room was very quiet.

Mary said, low and flat: "What do you want."

Jessamine looked at her. Something passed over the noble's face then: not warmth, nothing like it, but a kind of recognition. One calculator acknowledging another.

"I want to hire you," she said. "All three of you, as it happens, though I only came for one." She turned the navy eyes back to Jonah. "You're going into the Meridian Exchange on the seventeenth."

Mary's knife came the rest of the way out of her boot.

"Put that away, Miss Grieve. If I wanted you arrested you would already be in the Greystone and I would be at home in a bath." Jessamine didn't look at the blade. "My father sits on the board of the Rail Authority. I have read every security report on that building for two years because nobody in my house thinks a daughter can read a balance sheet, so nobody locks them up. Captain Thorne commands the Meridian guard on payroll nights. He has been asking his men about the coal loft at the edge of the yards, because someone has been

burning a candle up there at odd hours since spring." A beat. "You should move your drawings."

Mary went white.

"And a man called Markus Delaine," Jessamine went on, unhurried, "has been buying uniforms. Militia issue. Six of them, through a tailor on Chandler's Row who also, I believe, made Mr. Wren's suit." She glanced at Jonah. "It is a very good suit. Ferris should charge more."

"You've been following us," Jonah said.

"I've been following *money*. It led to you." She stood. In the small room, in the plain cloak, she was still taller than Mary and nearly as tall as him, and she stood the way she had on the balcony: spine straight, chin level, the line between them held. "I don't care about the payroll. Take every coin. Give it to the poor, drink it, pave the Lowers with it. In the basement of the Meridian, beside the vault, there is a records room. Freight manifests. Every cargo that has moved on the northern rail for eleven years."

From the doorway Sable made a small sound. Not a hiss. Something that caught in her throat on the way out.

Jessamine heard it. She didn't turn. "Some of those manifests," she said, more quietly, "list cargo shipped under my family's seal. I want them. The originals, not copies. That is my price for your name."

"Why?" Jonah said.

She looked at him for a long moment. The candle threw her shadow tall across the plaster behind her and the crack in the ceiling that looked like a coastline.

"Because I'm getting married in the spring, Mr. Wren," she said, "to Captain Aldric Thorne. And I would very much prefer not to."

She pulled her hood up. Took a card from inside her glove—heavy cream stock, no name, just an address on the fourth tier and a time, written in a clean, sharp, unhurried hand—and held it out to him.

He took it. Her gloved fingers didn't touch his.

"Tomorrow," she said. "Bring Miss Grieve. Bring her drawings. Burn the candle somewhere else." She stepped toward the door, and Mary didn't move out of her way, and for a moment the two of them stood a foot apart in the doorway—slate wool and patched leather, mahogany and dark auburn, the Crescent and the Lowers—and neither one blinked.

Then Mary stepped aside.

"Miss Grieve," Jessamine said, passing her.

"Lady Ashburn," said Mary, and made it sound like a curse.

Jessamine paused on the top step. She looked down at Sable, who had pressed herself flat against the railing, tail wrapped around her own leg, those enormous amber eyes fixed on the noblewoman's face.

"If what you're looking for is in that room," Jessamine said, "you'll find it under *A*."

Then she went down the stairs—*tk, tk, tk*, riding boots on old wood—and out into Bent Street, and a moment later Jonah heard a carriage door close somewhere out of sight and the sound of good horses walking away.

Nobody said anything.

Mary looked at the folded paper on the mattress. Jonah's name. Jonah's room. Bought for forty silvers and left behind like a calling card, because a woman like that didn't need to keep a thing to own it.

She picked it up. Unfolded it. Read it. Then she held the corner to the candle on the sill and watched it catch, and turn black, and curl, and she dropped it on the floorboards and ground the ash under her boot until there was nothing left.

"I hate her," Mary said.

"I know."

"I hate her so much I can taste it." She turned around. Her eyes were very bright and very hard. "Get your coat. We're moving my drawings tonight."

Sable was already on the stairs.



End of the draft · October 2026